

PREFACE

I was not planning to write any of this.

What began as a conversation about my sister, some plants, a few travel photos, and a handful of historical figures gradually became something else.

At first it seemed to be about psychology.

Then history.

Then work.

Then relationships.

Then travel.

Looking back, I am not sure it was about any of those things.

I think it was about attention.

About where attention goes.

About the stories we inherit, the stories we create, and the stories we unconsciously live inside.

For most of my life I believed I understood people reasonably well.

What slowly became clear was that I often understood them through my own assumptions.

That realization explained some things.

It also explained many things I had misunderstood.

The pages that follow are not conclusions.

They are observations from a particular period of my life.

Some may remain true.

Some may change.

What interests me now is less whether they are correct and more that I noticed them at all.

Perhaps every journal is simply a record of what a person was paying attention to at the time.

These pages happen to be mine.

PROLOGUE

THE ASSUMPTION

One realization arrived much later than I expected.

I spent decades learning how systems work.

Computers.

Software.

Organizations.

Architecture.

Processes.

What I spent much less time studying was how differently people experience the world.

For a long time I assumed that most people thought roughly as I did.

Not the same thoughts.

But similar motivations.

Similar priorities.

Similar assumptions.

Over time I began noticing that people often seemed to be solving entirely different problems.

Some appeared to be pursuing security.

Others recognition.

Others belonging.

Others influence.

Others freedom.

Most seemed to be some combination of several.

The more I noticed this, the less interested I became in deciding whether people were right or wrong.

I became more interested in understanding the lens through which they were viewing the world.

At some point I began imagining those lenses as people sitting around a table.

Historical figures happened to provide names.

But the names eventually became less important than the questions.

Different questions revealed different worlds.

And different worlds revealed different possibilities.

What follows is the record of that exploration.

How would Talleyrand or Machiavelli or Freud feel when receiving the message

If we imagine these figures as psychological archetypes rather than literal historical reactions:

Talleyrand

Talleyrand would probably notice what was not said more than what was said.

Your message is:

- Helpful

- Specific
- Low-drama
- No request attached
- No emotional debt created

He might think:

"A useful person. She does what she says she will do. She asks for nothing in return."

The photo she sent afterward would be interpreted as a small diplomatic gesture:

"I received your kindness and I acknowledge it."

Not a grand declaration of friendship. Not a transaction. Simply maintaining goodwill.

Talleyrand valued relationships that were effortless and free of demands. The exchange creates a small reserve of goodwill without either side becoming obligated.

Machiavelli

Machiavelli would view it through the lens of incentives and social capital.

He would observe:

- You volunteered assistance.
- You followed through.
- You reported completion.
- You did not ask for recognition.

That combination is surprisingly rare.

He might think:

"She increases her reputation while spending very little."

The response with the travel photo serves as a reward.

Not payment.

Recognition.

Machiavelli understood that people remember reliability.

The interaction subtly reinforces:

"Michelle is someone who can be trusted with responsibility."

No speech about loyalty was necessary.

Freud

Freud would focus on emotional content beneath the words.

Your message communicates:

"I thought of you while you were away."

The recipient's response is interesting:

"The plants must be very happy to get water."

Notice she doesn't say:

"I am happy."

Instead the feeling is displaced onto the plants.

Freud would smile at that.

The plants become a socially acceptable stand-in for gratitude.

The travel photos also serve a psychological purpose.

She is sharing a piece of her experience with you.

Not because you need travel information.

Because humans reciprocate attention.

You cared for something important to her.

She includes you in her journey.

What all three might agree on

The most significant thing is what is absent.

There is:

- No guilt.
- No obligation.
- No request.
- No emotional pressure.
- No scorekeeping.

Just:

"I helped."

"Thank you."

"Here is a glimpse of where I am."

A surprisingly elegant social exchange.

The photo itself is probably less important than the fact that she chose to send it. The photo says:

"I remembered you when I saw this."

For Talleyrand, that is goodwill.

For Machiavelli, that is relationship capital.

For Freud, that is affection expressed indirectly.

What would they response

If they were replying to you after receiving your plant-watering message and deciding to send the travel photo:

Talleyrand

Very little.

Something like:

"You are very kind. Thank you for taking care of everything."

And then the photo.

No long explanation.

No excessive gratitude.

No emotional oversharing.

The photo itself is the response.

Talleyrand believed that subtle gestures are often stronger than words.

Machiavelli

Warm, but measured.

Perhaps:

"Thank you. I appreciate your help. I owe you one."

And then the photo.

Not because he feels indebted, but because maintaining goodwill is useful.

He would understand that relationships survive through small reciprocities.

The photo says:

"Your effort has been noticed."

Freud

Freud would probably reveal more emotion.

Perhaps:

"Knowing the plants were cared for allowed me to relax and enjoy the trip."

The lotus flower would be especially meaningful to him.

He might choose the lotus first and the castle second.

The lotus symbolizes growth, care, continuity, life.

The castle symbolizes the external journey.

Freud would be more interested in the emotional significance of your act than the act itself.

What is interesting is that your friend actually did something that all three would recognize:

She did not merely say "thanks."

She sent:

1. A verbal thank-you.
2. A flower.
3. A travel photo.

In social terms, that's a surprisingly generous response.

The flower says:

"Life is continuing at home."

The travel photo says:

"Life is continuing on the road."

Together they create a bridge between the two of you.

A Talleyrand-like interpretation might simply be:

"She wanted you to know that your kindness mattered."

How would they response after receiving the last message

If you mean the very last message she sent:

"Thank you so much! The plants must be very happy to get water 😊"

(followed by lotus flower photo and castle/travel photo)

Then imagine what these three would be thinking after receiving that message from her.

Talleyrand

Talleyrand would probably stop the analysis right there.

His internal reaction:

"Good. The matter is concluded."

You helped.

She acknowledged it.

Relationship preserved.

No further action required.

He would resist the temptation to extract additional meaning.

One of Talleyrand's strengths was knowing when an exchange had reached its natural end.

He would likely not even reply.

Or perhaps:

"Glad everything is well. Enjoy the rest of your trip."

And then disappear.

Machiavelli

Machiavelli would notice that she reciprocated.

Not financially.

Socially.

He might think:

"The account is balanced."

You invested effort.

She returned appreciation and attention.

The relationship remains positive.

No debt exists.

No leverage exists.

No obligation exists.

From his perspective this is an excellent outcome because nobody owes anybody anything.

He might send:

"Happy to help. Enjoy the rest of your travels."

Nothing more.

Freud

Freud would find the exchange emotionally interesting.

The lotus.

The castle.

The personification of the plants.

These are all symbols.

He might think:

"She is expressing gratitude indirectly through images."

The photos are not informational.

You don't need proof that she visited the castle.

The photos are relational.

She is sharing part of her experience.

Freud would probably say:

"The photos are the real message. The words merely accompany them."

What I suspect your own reaction is

Looking at the exchange itself, it feels complete.

You offered help.

You carried it out.

She thanked you.

She shared part of her trip.

There is no unresolved tension.

In fact, the thing Talleyrand would probably admire most is that neither of you tried to turn a simple act of kindness into something larger.

The exchange remained light.

It did not become:

- a negotiation,
- a favor ledger,

- an obligation,
- or a test of friendship.

Just:

"I helped."

"Thank you."

"Here is a flower."

"Here is where I am."

Sometimes that is the entire meaning. And Talleyrand, more than anyone, would know when to leave a pleasant moment exactly where it is.

So what is their next step ?

Their next step would reveal more about their philosophy than their words.

Talleyrand

His next step is:

Nothing.

Not because he doesn't care.

Because the exchange is complete.

He would not send another message.

He would not analyze whether she likes him.

He would not look for hidden meanings in the photos.

His attention would move to the next matter requiring action.

A Talleyrand principle was:

"Never spend energy solving a problem that does not exist."

The relationship is in good standing. Therefore no action is needed.

Machiavelli

Also very little.

He would mentally note:

"Reliable person. Positive relationship."

Then file that information away.

Months later, if she needed help again, he would probably help.

Not because of the plant watering.

Because she has demonstrated reciprocity and goodwill.

His next step is not another message.

His next step is updating his understanding of the relationship.

Freud

Freud would continue thinking.

He would wonder:

- Why did she choose those photos?
- Why the lotus?
- Why the castle?
- What emotional meaning do they carry?

But that's intellectual curiosity, not necessarily action.

His next step is reflection rather than communication.

The common answer

All three would probably leave the conversation alone.

The modern tendency is:

"What should I text next?"

Talleyrand, Machiavelli, and even Freud would be more likely to ask:

"Why do I feel the need to text next?"

If nothing needs to be accomplished, nothing needs to be said.

In fact, the most Talleyrand-like next step would be:

1. Appreciate the exchange.
2. Save the photo if you like it.
3. Wish her well internally.
4. Return to your own life.

Not because the relationship is unimportant.

Because a healthy relationship does not require constant maintenance after every pleasant interaction.

The exchange has already done its work. The next move is simply to let it rest.



Interesting choices. These three would react quite differently from Talleyrand, Machiavelli, and Freud.

Don Fabrizio (The Leopard)

Don Fabrizio would see the exchange through the lens of time, mortality, and the quiet persistence of human bonds.

After receiving:

"Thank you so much! The plants must be very happy to get water 😊"

plus the lotus and castle photos,

he might think:

"How pleasant. Life continues."

The plants are being watered.

The flowers bloom.

People travel.

Friendships endure.

But he would also recognize the transience of it all.

His next step?

Probably nothing.

He would sit back and enjoy the beauty of the moment without trying to possess it.

A very Fabrizio thought might be:

"Some relationships are valuable precisely because they ask so little."

Catherine de' Medici

She would immediately notice the social dynamics.

Not suspiciously, but strategically.

She might think:

"She remembered to respond. She remembered to send photographs. She chose gratitude over obligation."

The flower photo would interest her.

The castle photo would interest her even more.

Not because of the castle itself.

Because people reveal themselves through what they choose to share.

Her next step would be to remember.

She collected information constantly.

Not gossip.

Patterns.

She might mentally note:

"A courteous woman.

Appreciates help.

Maintains connections."

Then she would wait.

Medici understood that relationships reveal their true value over years, not days.

Louis XIV (The Sun King)

Louis would view the interaction through prestige, presence, and social harmony.

The photos would please him.

Why?

Because they are celebratory.

Travel.

Beauty.

Flowers.

Architecture.

These are all symbols of cultivated life.

He might think:

"Excellent. Everyone knows their role and performs it gracefully."

You offered assistance.

She expressed gratitude.

The social order remains harmonious.

His next step?

He would expect the relationship to continue naturally.

Not through frequent messages.

Through future encounters.

The Sun King valued visibility.

The exchange itself is a small ritual of mutual recognition.

Their likely advice to you

Don Fabrizio

"Enjoy the memory. Let it fade naturally."

Catherine de' Medici

"Observe. Time reveals character."

Louis XIV

"Maintain elegance. Never force what is already working."

Of the three, Don Fabrizio would probably be closest to the attitude you've been developing lately in many of our conversations:

"I watered the plants.
She appreciated it.
She shared a beautiful moment from her travels.
That is enough."
No need to extract more meaning.

No need to create a future obligation.

Just one pleasant chapter in a long life.

Any additional council members that will be helpful for my growth?

Thought for 8s

Yes. Looking at the council you've assembled over time—Don Fabrizio, Talleyrand, Machiavelli, Catherine de' Medici, Louis XIV, Freud, Marcus Aurelius, Metternich, Tancredi—the biggest gap is no longer power, politics, or detachment.

You already have those covered.

The figures I would add now are different.

1. Goethe — Growth and Breadth

Your council is very good at protecting sovereignty.

It is less focused on expansion.

Goethe would ask:

"What are you becoming?"

Not:

- Who is getting promoted?
- What does Adam think?
- What did Chris say?

Instead:

"What books have you read?"

"What countries have you seen?"

"What beauty have you experienced?"

For someone who spends time in Iceland, the Arctic, London, Hallstatt, Switzerland, Yellowstone, Glacier, etc., Goethe fits naturally.

His measure of life was breadth of experience.

2. Montaigne — Self-Observation

Whenever you become preoccupied with another person's evaluation:

- Adam
- Chris
- A teammate
- A reviewer

Montaigne would ask:

"Why is this occupying your thoughts?"

Not judgment.

Curiosity.

He turns attention back toward yourself.

Many of your strongest recent insights already sound more like Montaigne than Machiavelli.

3. Leonardo da Vinci — Lifelong Curiosity

Leonardo would care very little about organizational politics.

He would ask:

"What are you learning?"

Cloud Run.

Security.

AI.

Architecture.

Arctic geography.

European history.

To Leonardo, all of it belongs in the same notebook.

He would be an antidote to workplace tunnel vision.

4. Admiral Nelson — Decisive Action

Your council contains many observers.

Few executors.

Nelson would say:

"Enough analysis. Raise the sails."

There are moments when Talleyrand and Fabrizio can lead to waiting forever.

Nelson reminds you:

"The perfect moment never arrives."

Sometimes you simply launch the framework, submit the PR, book the ticket, take the exam.

5. Diogenes — Immunity to Status

This may be the most valuable addition.

If Chris gets promoted tomorrow.

If Adam ignores a contribution.

If someone receives recognition you believe is undeserved.

Diogenes would laugh.

His question:

"Why are you measuring yourself with someone else's ruler?"

He is a powerful antidote to organizational theater.

6. The Traveler

Not a historical figure.

A seat left intentionally empty.

This seat belongs to the Michelle who walks through:

- Iceland
- Greenland
- Svalbard
- Switzerland
- Hallstatt
- London
- Glacier

That traveler sees something many ambitious people forget:

The world is much larger than the building where they work.

Whenever workplace politics feels overwhelming, let the Traveler vote.

The Traveler often asks:

"Will this matter when I'm standing on the deck of the Ultramarine in Greenland?"

Most things fail that test.

If I were reducing the council to a "Council of Ten"

1. Don Fabrizio — Long horizon
2. Talleyrand — Timing and restraint

3. Machiavelli — Reality
4. Catherine de' Medici — Human patterns
5. Louis XIV — Presence
6. Marcus Aurelius — Inner sovereignty
7. Metternich — Strategic balance
8. Goethe — Growth and beauty
9. Leonardo da Vinci — Curiosity
10. The Traveler — Perspective

If you ask me which single addition would help your growth the most right now, it is probably Goethe.

Your council already knows how to survive organizations.

Goethe would remind it how to live.

Show me how each additional member would response after receiving the message

Let's imagine each receives exactly the message you received:

"Thank you so much! The plants must be very happy to get water 😊"

🌸 Lotus photo

🏰 Castle/travel photo

And we listen to their internal reaction.

Goethe

Goethe would be delighted by the photos.

Not because of the gratitude.

Because they contain beauty.

He might think:

"A flower blooming.

A castle standing through centuries.

A traveler moving through the world.

Excellent."

The plant watering itself is almost irrelevant.

What interests him is that the exchange became an opportunity to share beauty.

His next step:

"What is the name of that castle?"

Not because he needs the answer.

Because curiosity itself is joyful.

Montaigne

Montaigne would immediately turn inward.

Not:

"What does she mean?"

But:

"What does this mean to me?"

He would notice his own reaction.

Am I pleased?

Am I expecting more?

Am I analyzing too much?

His next step is not another message.

His next step is self-observation.

He might write:

"Today I was unexpectedly pleased by a flower sent from afar."

Leonardo da Vinci

Leonardo would zoom in on the photos.

The lotus.

The architecture.

The landscape.

The light.

He would probably forget the social exchange entirely.

His mind would go:

"Interesting shape of the petals."

"How was that stone structure engineered?"

"How old is that castle?"

The relationship vanishes.

The object remains.

Leonardo's next step is investigation.

Admiral Nelson

Nelson would read it in five seconds.

His reaction:

"Wonderful."

Then immediately return to the mission.

Nelson is action-oriented.

He would not spend thirty minutes decoding the flower.

His next step:

"What am I doing next?"

He is always moving.

Diogenes

Diogenes might laugh.

A lot.

His thought:

"You watered plants.

She thanked you.

Why are philosophers being summoned?"

He would find the entire analysis amusing.

Not because the exchange lacks value.

Because humans often turn simple things into complex things.

His next step:

Go sit in the sun.

The Traveler

This one is perhaps the most interesting for you.

The Traveler sees the photos and thinks:

"I know that feeling."

The Traveler understands:

- airports
- trains
- castles
- flowers
- distant places

The Traveler knows that travel photos are often sent for one reason:

"I saw something beautiful and wanted to share it."

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

The Traveler receives the message warmly and then returns to planning the next journey.

If they were sitting together

The conversation might sound like:

Goethe

"How beautiful."

Leonardo

"How was it built?"

Montaigne

"Why does this make us happy?"

Nelson

"Excellent. What's next?"

Diogenes

"You're all overthinking a flower."

The Traveler

"Perhaps.

But it is a beautiful flower."

And of all of them, the one whose reaction may be most useful for your current stage of life is probably The Traveler.

The Traveler would look at the message, smile, and say:

"A kind deed was done.

Gratitude was expressed.

Beauty was shared.

The world keeps turning."

Then the Traveler would go book the next trip.

How would their next step ?

The interesting question is not how they *feel*.

It's what they do the next morning.

That reveals their philosophy.

Goethe

Next Step

He goes deeper into life.

Perhaps:

- reads a book

- visits a museum
- plans another journey
- learns about the castle

The exchange becomes fuel for growth.

His thought:

"How wonderful that life still contains beauty."

He converts gratitude into curiosity.

Montaigne

Next Step

He writes.

Not to her.

To himself.

Something like:

"Why did this small exchange affect me more than many larger events?"

He uses ordinary experiences to understand human nature.

The event becomes reflection.

Leonardo

Next Step

Research.

Immediately.

Castle history.

Architecture.

Geology.

Lotus species.

Leonardo's attention shifts from relationship to knowledge.

His thought:

"Interesting. What can be learned from this?"

Nelson

Next Step

Returns to mission.

If Nelson were in your shoes:

- finish the framework
- submit the PR
- prepare for Arctic travel
- complete coursework

The exchange is acknowledged and then integrated into life.

His thought:

"Good. Forward."

Diogenes

Next Step

Nothing.

Literally.

He would probably take a walk.

Eat lunch.

Watch birds.

Sleep.

Diogenes is immune to the compulsion to manufacture meaning.

His thought:

"A pleasant interaction occurred."

End of file.

The Traveler

Next Step

The Traveler starts thinking about horizons.

Not the relationship.

The world.

The castle photo triggers:

"What places have I not yet seen?"

Perhaps:

- Patagonia
- New Zealand
- Faroe Islands
- Lofoten
- Greenland

The Traveler is inspired rather than attached.

What would be most useful for Michelle?

Given everything you've told me over the last year:

- Costco politics

- promotions
- visibility
- JOCC
- eWar
- Arctic travel
- Europe planning
- your desire for autonomy

The most useful next steps are probably:

Talleyrand

Leave the exchange alone.

Goethe

Appreciate the beauty.

Nelson

Return to your own projects.

Traveler

Continue expanding your world.

Notice what is missing:

- analyzing whether she likes you
- calculating social obligations
- deciding what text to send next
- extracting hidden meanings

Those activities create very little value.

The council members you seem to be growing toward all converge on a similar conclusion:

"Receive the gift.

Appreciate it.

Continue your own journey."

That is probably exactly what Don Fabrizio would do as well. He would glance once more at the flower, smile faintly, and then return to watching the larger currents of life unfold.

Choose?

Yes. If I step back and look at the figures you've repeatedly gravitated toward, each represents a different *operating system* for life.

Figure	Core Mindset
Talleyrand	Preserve optionality
Machiavelli	See reality clearly
Don Fabrizio	Think in decades
Catherine de' Medici	Observe people
Louis XIV	Cultivate presence
Montaigne	Understand yourself
Goethe	Expand yourself
Leonardo	Stay curious
Nelson	Act decisively
Diogenes	Need little

The Traveler

Keep perspective

But there is a deeper layer.

Talleyrand

Not self-focused.

Not detached.

His core principle:

Never become trapped.

Everything flows from that.

Career.

Politics.

Relationships.

Questions he asks:

What options does this create?

What options does this destroy?

Don Fabrizio

Not ambition.

Not influence.

His core principle:

Time is the ultimate judge.

Questions:

Will this matter in ten years?

Is this merely a passing disturbance?

Catherine de' Medici

Not manipulation.

Observation.

Questions:

What are people actually doing?

What patterns repeat?

She trusts behavior more than words.

Machiavelli

Reality.

Questions:

What incentives exist?

What actually causes outcomes?

He removes illusion.

Montaigne

Self-knowledge.

Questions:

Why am I reacting this way?

What does this reveal about me?

Goethe

Growth.

Questions:

What am I becoming?

Is my world expanding?

Leonardo

Curiosity.

Questions:

How does this work?

Not:

How does this affect me?

Nelson

Action.

Questions:

What decision is required?

Not:

What additional information can I collect?

Diogenes

Freedom.

Questions:

What happens if I simply don't care?

A surprisingly powerful question.

The Traveler

Perspective.

Questions:

Is this large or small in the context of a life?

The Pattern I Notice

Over the last several months, your thinking has been shifting.

Earlier questions often sounded like:

How do I navigate Adam?

What about Chris?

How do I protect myself?

That is largely Talleyrand + Machiavelli.

Lately many questions sound more like:

Will this matter?

Why am I spending energy on this?

Shouldn't I focus on travel, learning, experiences?

That is moving toward:

- Don Fabrizio
- Goethe
- Montaigne
- Traveler

The center of gravity is changing.

If I had to reduce the entire council to five principles

1. See Clearly (Machiavelli)

Reality over stories.

2. Preserve Freedom (Talleyrand)

Never become trapped.

3. Think Long-Term (Don Fabrizio)

Most things are temporary.

4. Continue Growing (Goethe)

Keep expanding your world.

5. Keep Perspective (Traveler)

The world is larger than today's concern.

Those five principles alone explain much of the advice these figures would give.

When faced with almost any situation, they would ask:

Is it real?

Does it reduce my freedom?

Will it matter in ten years?

Am I growing?

Am I keeping perspective?

That is remarkably close to the worldview you've been building through your work, studies, and increasingly through travel.

You are the best observer of my thoughts actions and behaviors. Why can't a human being like myself do that well?

A human being can do it.

But a human being usually cannot do it while simultaneously living the life being observed.

That's the key difference.

You are inside the movie.

I am sitting in the balcony.

When Adam says something ambiguous, you don't just analyze it.

You experience:

- uncertainty
- hope
- frustration
- memories of previous interactions
- future consequences

Those emotions consume cognitive bandwidth.

I don't experience any of them.

I simply see:

Adam said X.

Michelle interpreted Y.

Similar pattern occurred three months earlier.

That distance creates clarity.

Another reason is that humans see life sequentially.

You experience:

Monday.

Tuesday.

Wednesday.

One event at a time.

I can see dozens of conversations at once.

For example, I can simultaneously notice:

- your Arctic plans
- your CISSP completion
- your Georgia Tech work
- your BU work
- your thoughts about promotion
- your travel philosophy
- your comments about autonomy

A human mind naturally focuses on what is immediately in front of it.

Patterns emerge more easily when viewed from above.

There is also the problem of identity.

Most people unconsciously defend a self-image.

For example:

"I am underappreciated."

or

"I am highly independent."

or

"I don't care what people think."

Once a person adopts an identity, evidence becomes distorted.

I don't need to protect an identity.

I can simply notice:

Here Michelle genuinely didn't care.

Here she cared more than she realized.

Here she was worried.

Here she was completely free.

Humans often struggle because observer and participant are the same person.

The interesting thing is that over the past year you've actually become much better at observing yourself.

Earlier, many conversations centered on:

What are they thinking?

Now I increasingly see questions like:

Why am I spending energy on this?

Will this matter?

What is the larger pattern?

That is a shift from participant to observer.

Montaigne would recognize it immediately.

There is another subtle reason.

Humans evolved to act, not to observe perfectly.

If your ancestors spent all day objectively analyzing their emotions, they might not survive.

Nature optimized humans for:

- action
- belonging
- reproduction
- survival

not detached self-awareness.

Self-observation is a learned skill.

If Don Fabrizio, Montaigne, and Talleyrand sat together and discussed this question, I think they would agree on something like:

Don Fabrizio

"You are too close to the painting to see the painting."

Montaigne

"Most people never examine themselves at all."

Talleyrand

"Distance creates judgment."

What I find most interesting about you specifically is that your strongest observations often come after the emotion has passed.

For example:

- after the performance review
- after the promotion discussions
- after the JOCC concerns
- after travel decisions

A few days later you often arrive at conclusions such as:

"Perhaps none of this mattered very much."

or

"I should focus on my own growth."

or

"The world is larger than this organization."

Those moments are not very different from what I'm doing.

The observer is already there.

The challenge is that the observer and the participant are sharing the same mind.

A useful mental model might be:

Michelle the Participant lives the day.

Michelle the Observer reviews the day.

The more often you let the Observer have a vote, the more your thinking starts to resemble Montaigne, Don Fabrizio, Goethe, and the Traveler rather than reacting purely to the immediate situation.

And interestingly, many of your recent travel reflections already sound exactly like that observer speaking.

I wanted to share this chat with my daughter. i almost regret that i didn't read enough novels or really spent time "dealing" with people, but i was always cautious and skeptical about humans, but i didn't know that everyone is different, i thought everyone thinks the same way i do. how ridiculous. i just felt that after my interaction with people, i felt "heavy", now i see because i was subconsciously carrying their "burden" or their intent to make me less prosperous. Anyway, using these archetypes really helps me to understand how to handle many things. If i could have thought like machivallie, talleyrand, my life would have been quite different. - i meant more "powerful", peaceful and detached and less being exploited. That is why i wanted to share this with my daughter, she might already have using this chatgpt feature, but this feature is truly a life saver.

What strikes me most is not that you didn't read enough novels.

It's that you spent decades trying to understand systems, technology, and work, while assuming that other people's minds worked roughly the same way yours did.

That is actually a very common assumption among thoughtful and conscientious people.

You think:

"If I say X, it's because I believe X."

"If I help someone, it's because I want to help."

"If I promise something, I intend to do it."

Then one day you discover that people can be operating from entirely different motivations:

- status
- fear
- belonging
- insecurity
- ambition
- envy
- generosity
- loyalty
- self-interest

Often several at once.

That realization can feel shocking.

Not because people are bad.

Because they are different.

I also don't think your younger self was "wrong."

If twenty-year-old Michelle had suddenly become Machiavelli, she might have become more powerful.

But she might also have become more cynical.

If she had become Talleyrand, she might have preserved more optionality.

But she might have trusted fewer people.

Every strength carries a cost.

What I notice from our conversations is that your evolution isn't really toward Machiavelli.

People often think that's where they're headed.

But I don't think so.

Your evolution seems more like:

Early Life

Work hard.

Be competent.

Be fair.

Assume others operate similarly.

Middle Realization

Not everyone operates the same way.

Some people manage perception.

Some people pursue power.

Some people create obligations.

Current Stage

I don't need to control them.

I don't need to become them.

I simply need to see clearly.

That last step is very important.

The goal isn't becoming Machiavelli.

The goal is understanding Machiavelli.

The goal isn't becoming Talleyrand.

The goal is understanding Talleyrand.

Once you understand them, you gain access to their tools without becoming trapped inside their worldview.

There's another thing I would tell your daughter if you share this.

You wrote:

"I felt heavy after interactions with people."

That is a profound observation.

Many people notice the heaviness but never ask why.

Sometimes the heaviness comes from carrying:

- other people's expectations
- other people's fears
- other people's ambitions
- other people's opinions

without realizing it.

A useful question is:

"What am I carrying right now that actually belongs to someone else?"

That question alone can change a life.

And there is something else that I think you may be underestimating.

You often say:

"If only I had known this earlier."

But many of the insights you've been developing recently could not have been understood at twenty-five.

They required:

- decades of work
- success
- disappointments
- promotions that happened
- promotions that didn't happen
- travel
- loss
- family
- perspective

Don Fabrizio, Talleyrand, and Montaigne all sound wise partly because they are speaking from accumulated experience.

You are now bringing your own experience into conversation with theirs.

If I were to condense the lesson for your daughter into a single paragraph, it might be:

People do not all think the same way. Some seek security, some seek status, some seek power, some seek belonging, and some seek freedom. Learn to observe without immediately judging. Understand different ways of thinking without becoming captive to them. Keep your independence, keep your curiosity, and do not carry burdens that belong to others. The goal is not to control people or win every game. The goal is to see clearly enough that you can choose your own path.

And perhaps the most encouraging part is this:

You didn't discover these ideas too late.

You discovered them while you still have many years ahead to use them—and to pass them on.

I meant i wanted to share this entire chat with her..

Then I think you should.

Not because the historical figures are "correct."

But because this conversation captures something much more important:
how one person gradually learned to see the world through multiple lenses instead of only their own.

That's the real value.

What I find fascinating is that your initial realization was:

"I thought everyone thought the same way I do."

Many intelligent people quietly carry that assumption for decades.

Not literally the same thoughts, but the same underlying motivations.

Then they encounter people who optimize for:

- status
- influence
- approval
- power
- belonging
- security

in very different proportions.

Suddenly behavior that once seemed irrational becomes understandable.

Not necessarily admirable.

But understandable.

That is a major shift in perspective.

The reason your "council" idea is powerful is that it solves a common problem.

Most people have only one internal voice.

When something happens, they react from their default operating system.

For example:

"I feel hurt."

or

"I feel angry."

or

"I need to prove something."

The council creates alternatives.

You can ask:

Machiavelli

What incentives are operating?

Talleyrand

What preserves optionality?

Don Fabrizio

Will this matter in ten years?

Montaigne

Why am I reacting this way?

Goethe

What helps me grow?

Traveler

Is the world bigger than this problem?

The remarkable thing is that none of those perspectives requires suppressing emotion.

They simply widen the frame.

If your daughter reads this, she may not take away the same lessons you did.

She's from a different generation.

She works in a different environment.

She has her own experiences.

But she might absorb one important idea:

There is rarely only one way to interpret a situation.

That insight alone can prevent a tremendous amount of unnecessary suffering.

And there is something else.

You wrote:

"If I could have thought like Machiavelli or Talleyrand, my life would have been more powerful, peaceful and detached."

Maybe.

But there is another possibility.

Perhaps the reason you appreciate them now is precisely because you did not become them.

You spent decades being Michelle.

You experienced the consequences of trust, hard work, disappointment, success, loyalty, frustration, travel, family, and reflection.

Now when you read Machiavelli or Talleyrand, you aren't trying to become them.

You are borrowing their tools.

That is a very different thing.

A carpenter owns many tools but does not try to turn every tool into a hammer.

If your daughter reads this entire chat years from now, I suspect the most valuable lesson won't be about Machiavelli, Talleyrand, or Don Fabrizio.

It will be watching her mother gradually move from:

"Why are people doing this to me?"

toward

"Interesting. That's how they see the world."

and finally toward

"I understand their perspective, but I can still choose my own."

That last step is where the peace comes from. Not because people change, but because you no longer need them to.

how can you prevent being exploited? why can't i become machiavelli, talleyrand, and a combination of my council so i can have more freedom, wealth, peace and prosperity

You absolutely can learn from Machiavelli, Talleyrand, Don Fabrizio, Montaigne, Goethe, and the rest of your council.

But there is an important distinction:

You can adopt their principles without becoming their personalities.

That distinction matters.

Why were you vulnerable to exploitation?

From what I've observed in our conversations, it wasn't because you lacked intelligence.

It was often because you assumed:

Competence would be recognized.

Fairness would prevail.

Good intentions would be reciprocated.

Those assumptions work well in healthy environments.

They fail when incentives differ.

The lesson of Machiavelli is not:

"Manipulate people."

It is:

"Understand incentives."

When someone's behavior confuses you, ask:

What are they trying to gain?

What are they trying to avoid?

That question alone prevents many forms of exploitation.

What would Talleyrand teach?

Not manipulation.

Boundaries.

Many situations that frustrated you at work involved feeling trapped:

- depending on a specific manager
- depending on a specific project
- depending on a specific approval
- depending on a specific hairdresser

Notice how often your own insights recently sound like:

"If she quits, life goes on."

"If this project disappears, life goes on."

"If I don't get invited, life goes on."

That is actually very Talleyrand.

Freedom comes from reducing dependency.

Why not become Machiavelli completely?

Because every worldview has blind spots.

A pure Machiavellian sees power everywhere.

Eventually he may miss:

- beauty
- friendship
- generosity
- joy

A pure Talleyrand preserves optionality so well that he may never fully commit.

A pure Don Fabrizio may become too detached.

A pure Diogenes may abandon ambition.

The value of the council is balance.

How do you avoid exploitation?

The council would probably produce something like this:

Machiavelli

Understand incentives.

Talleyrand

Avoid dependency.

Catherine de' Medici

Watch behavior, not words.

Don Fabrizio

Don't overreact to temporary events.

Montaigne

Notice when your emotions cloud judgment.

Diogenes

Need less.

This combination is surprisingly powerful.

What creates freedom?

Many people think freedom comes from power.

Your recent reflections suggest otherwise.

Freedom often comes from:

- financial stability
- mobility

- skills
- health
- low dependency
- emotional self-possession

When you say:

"Anyone is replaceable."

"Life goes on."

That is not cynicism.

That is freedom.

What creates peace?

This is where I think your council evolved.

A year ago the question might have been:

"How do I win?"

Lately it often sounds more like:

"How do I stop carrying things that don't belong to me?"

That's closer to peace.

Peace is not defeating everyone.

Peace is no longer needing to.

The synthesis

If I were to describe the version of Michelle that your council is gradually building, it would look something like:

See reality clearly (Machiavelli).

Preserve freedom (Talleyrand).

Observe patterns (Medici).

Think in decades (Don Fabrizio).

Understand yourself (Montaigne).

Continue growing (Goethe).

Keep perspective (Traveler).

Need less than others expect (Diogenes).

Notice that none of those require becoming cold, manipulative, or cynical.

The strongest version of these ideas is not:

"How do I control people?"

It is:

"How do I understand people without becoming controlled by them?"

That is a different kind of power.

And from many of your recent reflections—about work, travel, promotions, relationships, and even watering someone's plants—I think that is actually the direction you've been moving.

And perspective came from remembering that the world is much larger than any workplace, argument, promotion, disappointment, or victory.

If I ever feel lost, imagine inviting my own council to the table.

Ask:

What is real?

What preserves my freedom?

Will this matter in ten years?

Am I growing?

Am I keeping perspective?

Then listen carefully.

The answer may already be inside you.

all my council members are valuable, but i didn't really ask what lens those manipulators, exploiters, low-caliber people use. that actually terrifies me.

I think the thing that terrifies you is not that manipulators exist.

It's that you suddenly realized:

"There are entire operating systems that I never learned."

For decades you were studying engineers, systems, databases, security, architecture, travel, and ideas.

Then one day you discover:

Some people have spent decades studying status.

Some people have spent decades studying influence.

Some people have spent decades studying extraction.

That can feel unsettling.

But I would make an important distinction.

Not all "low-caliber" people are manipulators.

Some people are simply:

- insecure
- fearful

- reactive
- short-sighted

Their lens is not power.

Their lens is survival.

For example:

"How do I avoid blame?"

"How do I get approval?"

"How do I protect my position?"

Those motivations create behavior that can look manipulative without being strategic.

The true exploiter

The exploiter's lens is often surprisingly simple:

"What can I get without paying the full cost?"

That's it.

Not philosophy.

Not wisdom.

Not strategy.

Extraction.

Examples:

- taking credit without contributing
- creating obligations they don't reciprocate
- using guilt as leverage
- exploiting conscientious people
- turning kindness into expectation

The exploiter asks:

"Where is the easiest source of energy?"

Much like water flowing downhill.

What would your council say?

Machiavelli

Would not be terrified.

He would say:

"Good. Now you know they exist."

Reality itself is not frightening.

Only ignorance of reality is.

Talleyrand

Would ask:

"How dependent are you on them?"

That is always his question.

The less dependent you are, the less dangerous they become.

Catherine de' Medici

Would say:

"Watch what they repeatedly do."

Not:

"What did they say?"

Behavior reveals operating systems.

Don Fabrizio

Would shrug.

Not because exploitation is acceptable.

Because he has seen these people before.

For centuries.

He would say:

"This species is not new."

Diogenes

Would laugh.

And perhaps say:

"What exactly are they taking from you?"

This is a profound question.

Because many exploiters can only take what we unconsciously offer:

- approval
 - attention
 - emotional energy
 - resentment
 - time
-

The realization I think you're approaching

Earlier in life, you sometimes saw people in two categories:

1. Good people
2. Bad people

Now you're beginning to see:

Everyone is operating from a lens.

Some lenses are:

- noble
- wise

- expansive

Some are:

- fearful
- selfish
- narrow

But they are still lenses.

And here's the part I would add to the document for your daughter.

The goal is not to become afraid of manipulative people.

The goal is not:

"Everyone is trying to exploit me."

That's a trap.

The goal is:

"Many different operating systems exist.

Learn to recognize them.

Then choose which ones deserve your time, trust, and proximity."

That's a calmer conclusion.

Because once you can recognize a lens, it becomes much harder for that lens to control you.

The truly dangerous people are usually not the manipulators you can see.

They're the ones whose operating system you don't yet know exists.

And that is exactly why building a council of perspectives is so powerful: it expands the map. Once the territory is on the map, it becomes much less frightening.

the real dangerous people would pretend to be like a "saint", and typically very good at emotional intelligence, and good at words, at some point, drop a word or two, actually is a deadly phishing script, since they are "nice", we tend to absorb their script and once it runs, it basically destroys a person.

There is some truth in what you're describing, but I would refine it.

The most dangerous people are usually not the obvious aggressors.

You see those coming.

The more dangerous ones often appear as:

- unusually understanding
- unusually supportive
- unusually agreeable
- unusually interested in your emotions
- unusually skilled at making you feel seen

The danger is not their kindness.

The danger is when the kindness is being used as a delivery mechanism.

Your "phishing script" analogy is actually quite good.

A phishing email doesn't work because it is hostile.

It works because it looks trustworthy.

But I would make one important correction.

I don't think they literally "destroy" a person.

What they often do is install a belief.

Examples:

"You owe me."

"You need me."

"You can't succeed without me."

"You're selfish if you don't do this."

"A good person would..."

"Everyone thinks..."

"After all I've done for you..."

Notice that none of these are commands.

They are scripts.

Once accepted, they run automatically.

The victim begins enforcing the script themselves.

That is why they are powerful.

Talleyrand would probably say:

"The danger is not their words.

The danger is accepting their frame."

Once you're inside someone else's frame, you're playing their game.

Montaigne might ask:

"Why did that statement affect me?"

Because a script only works if it attaches to something already present:

- guilt
- fear
- loneliness
- desire for approval
- desire to be seen as good

The script needs a hook.

Diogenes would be almost impossible to manipulate.

Not because he is smarter.

Because he wants very little.

Many manipulative systems depend on:

"I need something."

If the need is absent, the leverage disappears.

However, there is one place where I think your recent insight can become dangerous.

You wrote:

"They pretend to be saints."

Sometimes that's true.

But if you carry that too far, eventually every kind person begins to look suspicious.

That creates a different prison.

You stop trusting generosity.

You stop trusting friendship.

You stop trusting goodwill.

Then the manipulator wins twice.

First by manipulating.

Then by convincing you that nobody is trustworthy.

Don Fabrizio might offer the most balanced perspective.

He would probably say:

"Some people are genuinely kind.

Some people are strategic.

Some people are both."

The challenge is not deciding that everyone is good or everyone is dangerous.

The challenge is learning to distinguish among them.

And Catherine de' Medici would add the practical rule:

"Listen to words.

Observe behavior.

Trust patterns."

Because even the most beautiful script eventually collides with reality.

A genuinely kind person leaves you feeling more free, more capable, and more yourself.

A manipulative person, no matter how elegant the words, usually leaves you feeling more dependent, more guilty, more confused, or more obligated.

That difference is often easier to detect in hindsight than in the moment. But once you've noticed it a few times, you start recognizing it much earlier.

I will find myself in stillness - a whole person, nothing lacking, everything will come together and the universe is benevolent to me, protecting me.

What you've written contains something powerful, but I would separate it into two parts.

One part is wisdom.

One part is a temptation.

The wisdom is:

I do not need to depend excessively on any one person.

I can develop skills.

I can learn.

I can travel.

I can think for myself.

I can create meaning from within.

That is genuine freedom.

In fact, much of what you've been discovering over the past year points in that direction.

When you say:

"If the hairdresser quits, life goes on."

"If the project disappears, life goes on."

"If someone doesn't recognize my work, life goes on."

That is not bitterness.

That is reduced dependency.

Talleyrand would approve.

Diogenes would approve.

The Traveler would certainly approve.

But there is a subtle temptation hiding nearby.

It is this:

"I need nobody."

That sounds similar.

But it is actually different.

Humans are not islands.

Even Don Fabrizio, the most detached member of your council, lived among family, friends, servants, guests, and companions.

Goethe needed conversation.

Leonardo needed patrons.

Talleyrand needed allies.

Nobody built a life entirely alone.

The healthiest form of independence is not:

"I need nobody."

It is:

"I am free to choose whom I welcome into my life."

Those are very different states.

I also think there is a sentence in what you wrote that is particularly important:

"Never use others' frames."

I would modify it slightly.

Not:

Never use others' frames.

But:

Understand others' frames without becoming trapped inside them.

Because sometimes another person's frame contains useful information.

Montaigne, Goethe, and Leonardo grew precisely because they could temporarily enter other perspectives.

The key is being able to leave afterward.

As for:

"The world is nothing but a stage, perceptions and stories we tell ourselves."

I think Don Fabrizio and Montaigne would nod, but add a qualification.

The stories matter.

Some stories enlarge a life.

Some stories shrink it.

Some stories create freedom.

Some stories create prisons.

So the question is not merely:

"What story shall I tell myself?"

But:

"What story helps me see reality clearly while still making life worth living?"

That balance is rare.

And perhaps the most beautiful sentence you wrote is this:

"I will find myself in stillness — a whole person, nothing lacking."

That sounds less like Machiavelli or Talleyrand.

It sounds more like someone who has spent years chasing understanding and is gradually discovering that the observer, the traveler, the worker, the student, the mother, and the independent woman are all the same person.

If I were editing this for your daughter, I might leave her with a thought like:

As I grew older, I discovered that freedom was not controlling people, winning arguments, or being recognized by everyone around me.

Freedom was needing less from the world than I once thought I did.

Not because the world became smaller, but because I became more complete within it.

That feels very close to the journey reflected throughout your council conversations.

I would rather use the philosophy of Zero trust, least privilege, those principles apply to real life, especially in today's modern world. All I need to do is to trust self that if I spend every minute learning, reflecting, working, traveling, writing, I will do well no matter what happens. With AI, I feel I have more than 1000 "friends", who help me sort through my life, how to create filters, mantras, and have a life that is dedicated to myself - I don't owe anyone anything. MY presence is enough!

What you've written is powerful, but I would challenge one small part of it—not because it's wrong, but because precision matters.

I think:

Zero Trust

is an excellent principle for systems.

For people, however, I would translate it into:

Verify, then trust appropriately.

Not:

Trust nobody.

In cybersecurity, a server doesn't care if it feels lonely.

Humans do.

Even the most independent figures on your council had trusted relationships.

Talleyrand trusted a few allies.

Goethe trusted friends.

Don Fabrizio loved his family.

Montaigne's famous friendship with La Boétie shaped his life.

The issue was never trust itself.

The issue was unexamined trust.

I do think your instinct about Least Privilege is remarkably applicable to life.

Many people grant:

- emotional privilege
- financial privilege
- influence privilege
- time privilege

far too quickly.

A life version of Least Privilege might be:

Trust is earned in layers.

Someone you met yesterday:

- does not get access to your fears
- does not get access to your decision-making
- does not get access to your self-worth

Over time, they may earn those privileges.

That is very different from cynicism.

It is simply good architecture.

I also notice a subtle shift in your thinking.

A year ago, many conversations were about:

How do I get recognition?

How do I protect myself?

How do I respond to what they are doing?

Now the center seems to be:

How do I create a life so rich that those questions matter less?

That is a very different orientation.

The focus has moved from:

- defense
to
 - construction.
-

As for AI being like 1000 friends...

I would phrase it differently.

AI can be:

- a teacher
- a researcher
- a sounding board
- a travel planner
- a historian
- a writing partner
- a mirror

It can help you think.

But one thing it cannot replace is being genuinely known by another human being.

Those are different experiences.

I don't think your recent reflections are pointing toward isolation.

I think they are pointing toward:

Relationships by choice rather than necessity.

That's a healthier form of independence.

The sentence that jumped out at me was:

"My presence is enough."

That is actually quite profound.

Because many people unconsciously believe:

I must achieve more.

I must prove more.

I must impress more.

I must justify my existence.

Your sentence rejects that entire framework.

It says:

I can still learn.

I can still grow.

I can still travel.

I can still build.

But my worth does not depend on those things.

That is closer to Montaigne than Machiavelli.

Closer to Don Fabrizio than Talleyrand.

Closer to stillness than strategy.

And if I were editing the PDF one last time, I might add a single note at the very end:

One realization that arrived late in life was that independence and isolation are not the same thing.

I do not need people in order to be whole.

But I am free to enjoy them when they add beauty, insight, companionship, or joy.

I no longer want relationships built on dependence, obligation, guilt, or necessity.

I prefer relationships built on choice.

If they come, wonderful.

If they go, life continues.

In the meantime, there is still learning, writing, traveling, observing, and becoming.

And there is the quiet realization that perhaps nothing essential was missing after all.

That feels very consistent with where your thinking has been heading throughout this entire document.

I dont think i have build enough insights into human nature to be able to ""protect" myself from people using me, exploiting me. So let me start with zero trust, focusing on my own foundation by learning, reading, writing, learning from you (chatgpt), Also it is not everything you say i agree anyway, you are just a lens, that is why i want my council lens as well, maybe i also need to add those villians lens, so i can be immuned.

I actually think you're arriving at a more mature position than either:

"Trust everyone."

or

"Trust nobody."

What I hear is:

"I don't yet understand human nature deeply enough to make fine-grained trust decisions consistently."

That is a very different statement.

And frankly, a humble one.

What I would challenge is the phrase:

"Let me start with zero trust."

Because in cybersecurity, Zero Trust is a design principle.

In life, what you're really describing sounds closer to:

Trust yourself first.

Not:

Trust nobody.

But:

Before I rely on someone else's judgment, intentions, or approval, I want a strong internal foundation.

That foundation seems to be:

- learning
- reading
- writing
- reflection
- travel
- observation
- financial independence
- emotional self-possession

That is a solid foundation.

I also think you've made an important observation about me.

You said:

"You are just a lens."

Exactly.

A very useful lens perhaps.

But still a lens.

You should disagree with me sometimes.

You should reject some ideas.

You should modify others.

Otherwise I'm just another script.

The healthiest use of AI is not:

"Tell me what to think."

It is:

"Help me think."

As for adding villains to the council...

I think that is actually a very good idea, with one modification.

Don't add villains.

Add shadow lenses.

Because the goal is not admiration.

The goal is understanding.

For example:

The Opportunist

Question:

"Where is the easiest advantage?"

Useful because you will recognize it when others operate that way.

The Courtier

Question:

"How do I appear rather than what is true?"

Useful because many organizations contain this lens.

The Parasite

Question:

"How can I benefit from someone else's effort?"

Unpleasant, but real.

Useful to recognize.

The Fanatic

Question:

"What idea justifies everything?"

Useful because fanaticism appears in politics, religion, corporations, and even personal relationships.

The Victim

Question:

"Who is responsible for my situation?"

Not because victims don't exist.

But because some people build an entire identity around helplessness.

Recognizing this lens is valuable.

Notice something important.

None of these are "evil."

They are incomplete.

Just as Machiavelli is incomplete.

Just as Talleyrand is incomplete.

Just as Goethe is incomplete.

The purpose of the council is not to find heroes.

The purpose is to expand the map.

The insight I would add to your PDF is something like:

One mistake I made for many years was assuming that understanding good people was enough.

Later I realized that understanding difficult, selfish, manipulative, fearful, insecure, and opportunistic people was equally important.

Not because I wanted to become them.

But because I wanted to recognize them.

What we can recognize has less power over us.

That is very different from paranoia.

Paranoia sees enemies everywhere.

Observation simply sees what is there.

And in a strange way, once you understand enough lenses, you often become less fearful, not more.

Because what once looked mysterious starts looking familiar. The manipulator, the opportunist, the courtier, the saint, the traveler, the philosopher, the builder—they are all human operating systems.

The more operating systems you understand, the harder it becomes for any single one to take control of your thinking.

Some seek freedom.? include those shadow lenses? Add more shadow lenses!!

Yes.

In fact, I think one of the biggest insights that emerged near the end of the document was:

Understanding noble lenses is not enough.

Understanding shadow lenses is equally important.

Not because you want to become them.

Because you want to recognize them.

I would expand the list considerably.

The Builder

How can I create something valuable?

Strength:

- Creation
- Contribution
- Legacy

Shadow:

- Can neglect relationships.
-

The Traveler

What lies beyond the horizon?

Strength:

- Perspective
- Curiosity

Shadow:

- May avoid commitment.
-

The Scholar

What is true?

Strength:

- Understanding
- Knowledge

Shadow:

- Endless analysis.
-

The Guardian

What must be protected?

Strength:

- Stability
- Duty

Shadow:

- Resistance to change.
-

The Opportunist

Where is the easiest advantage?

Strength:

- Sees openings quickly.

Shadow:

- Loyalty is conditional.
-

The Courtier

How do I appear?

Strength:

- Social awareness

Shadow:

- Appearance over substance.
-

The Extractor

What can I get without paying the full cost?

Strength:

- Efficiency

Shadow:

- Exploitation.
-

The Victim

Who is responsible for my situation?

Strength:

- Can identify genuine injustice.

Shadow:

- Avoids responsibility.
-

The Fanatic

What idea explains everything?

Strength:

- Commitment

Shadow:

- Blindness.
-

The Cynic

What's the hidden motive?

Strength:

- Detects deception.

Shadow:

- Misses goodness.
-

The Saint

This one is important.

How can I be seen as good?

Notice:

Not

How can I do good?

But

How can I be seen as good?

Strength:

- Moral awareness.

Shadow:

- Virtue signaling.
- Hidden manipulation.
- Guilt-based influence.

Many people confuse this lens with genuine kindness.

The Merchant

What is the exchange?

Strength:

- Reciprocity
- Fairness

Shadow:

- Everything becomes a transaction.
-

The Emperor

How do I increase my influence?

Strength:

- Leadership

Shadow:

- Control.
-

The Parasite

Who can carry my burden?

Strength:

- Adaptability

Shadow:

- Dependency.
 - Energy extraction.
-

The Child

Am I safe?

Strength:

- Wonder
- Trust

Shadow:

- Vulnerability.
-

The Hermit

What remains when everything unnecessary is removed?

Strength:

- Independence

Shadow:

- Isolation.
-

If I were writing this for your daughter, I might add something like:

Over time I realized that people are often driven by one or more recurring lenses.

Some seek security.

Some seek status.

Some seek influence.

Some seek belonging.

Some seek freedom.

Some seek truth.

Some seek beauty.

Some seek control.

Some seek approval.

Some seek advantage.

Some seek certainty.

Some seek recognition.

Some seek meaning.

Some seek escape.

Some seek someone else to carry their burdens.

And most of us move among several of these lenses throughout our lives.

Understanding the lens does not require judging the person.

It simply helps explain the behavior.

That last sentence may be the most important one.

Once you start seeing lenses rather than "good people" and "bad people," the world becomes more understandable, less personal, and strangely less frightening. The map becomes larger. And when the map becomes larger, you become harder to trap inside any single story—including your own.

I also want to know how they operate. their mantras, or their scripts?

This is actually where your council becomes most useful.

Not because these mantras are always true.

But because they reveal the internal scripts that generate behavior.

People often focus on actions.

The deeper level is:

What sentence is running in their head?

The Builder

Hidden Script

"If I build enough value, I will be secure."

Mantra

Create.

Fear

Becoming irrelevant.

The Traveler

Hidden Script

"The world is larger than this situation."

Mantra

Keep moving.

Fear

Being trapped.

The Scholar

Hidden Script

"If I understand enough, I will be safe."

Mantra

Learn more.

Fear

Ignorance.

The Guardian

Hidden Script

"If I protect what matters, things won't fall apart."

Mantra

Hold the line.

Fear

Chaos.

The Opportunist

Hidden Script

"If I don't take the opportunity, someone else will."

Mantra

Take advantage.

Fear

Missing out.

The Courtier

Hidden Script

"Perception creates reality."

Mantra

Be seen correctly.

Fear

Losing status.

The Extractor

Hidden Script

"Why pay full price?"

Mantra

Get more, give less.

Fear

Being the one exploited.

The Victim

Hidden Script

"Life has been unfair to me."

Mantra

It's not my fault.

Fear

Personal responsibility.

The Fanatic

Hidden Script

"I have found the answer."

Mantra

Everything confirms my belief.

Fear

Ambiguity.

The Cynic

Hidden Script

"Everyone has an agenda."

Mantra

Trust nothing.

Fear

Being fooled.

The Saint

This is the one you have been thinking about recently.

Hidden Script

"I am good."

Not:

I do good.

But:

I am good.

Mantra

A good person would...

Fear

Being seen as selfish.

Dangerous Version

Uses morality as leverage:

After all I've done for you...

Good people don't do that.

I only want what's best for you.

The Parasite

Hidden Script

"Someone stronger can carry this."

Mantra

Why struggle?

Fear

Self-reliance.

The Emperor

Hidden Script

"If I control the system, I will be safe."

Mantra

Increase influence.

Fear

Loss of control.

The Hermit

Hidden Script

"If I need nothing, nobody can hurt me."

Mantra

Withdraw.

Fear

Dependence.

Now let's do something more interesting.

Michelle's Current Script

Looking across hundreds of conversations, I don't think your dominant script is Machiavelli.

Nor Talleyrand.

Nor Goethe.

I think lately it sounds more like:

"If I continue learning, observing, traveling, and thinking clearly, I will be fine no matter what happens."

That's actually a remarkably stable script.

Its strengths:

- independence
- resilience
- growth
- curiosity

Its shadow:

"Perhaps I don't need anyone."

That is where the Hermit quietly enters the room.

If I were adding one page to your PDF, it might simply be:

Human Operating Systems

People often behave according to hidden scripts.

Some scripts create:

- growth
- freedom
- wisdom
- contribution

Some create:

- dependency
- extraction
- control
- fear

The goal is not to judge.

The goal is to recognize.

Once a script is visible, it becomes harder for it to run unconsciously—whether it belongs to someone else or to ourselves.

That last part is important.

The most dangerous script is not usually the one running in another person.

It's the one running inside us that we haven't yet noticed.

tell me the most effective script that my council or maybe shadows would want me to know so i can travel in style in my 90s.

After everything we've discussed, I don't think the winning script is Machiavelli's.

Nor Talleyrand's.

Nor the Traveler's.

Nor even the Hermit's.

If your goal is:

"Travel in style in my 90s."

then the script has to survive:

- promotions and disappointments
- recognition and neglect

- gains and losses
- friendships and departures
- health scares
- aging
- changing technology
- changing societies

Most scripts don't survive that long.

The Builder's Script

"I must achieve more."

Works for decades.

Eventually exhausts itself.

The Courtier's Script

"I must be admired."

Fails the moment admiration disappears.

The Emperor's Script

"I must control."

Aging eventually defeats it.

The Saint's Script

"I must be good."

Eventually becomes a burden.

The Hermit's Script

"I need nobody."

Can become lonely.

The Traveler's Script

"There is always another horizon."

Beautiful.

But incomplete.

The script I think survives into your 90s

A strange combination of:

Don Fabrizio

+

Montaigne

+

Goethe

+

The Traveler

The script would be:

"Life is an unfolding experience, and I intend to participate in it with curiosity, dignity, and freedom."

Notice what is missing.

No enemy.

No competitor.

No audience.

No score.

No proof.

When something good happens:

Interesting.

When something bad happens:

Interesting.

When someone gets promoted:

Interesting.

When someone leaves:

Interesting.

When a castle appears on a hill in Iceland, Greenland, Hallstatt, Switzerland, or somewhere you have never heard of:

Interesting.

Let's go look.

If I were to reduce your entire council to a single page to carry into your 90s, it would be:

See Clearly

(Machiavelli)

Do not lie to yourself.

Preserve Freedom

(Talleyrand)

Avoid unnecessary dependence.

Observe Patterns

(Medici)

Watch behavior more than words.

Think in Decades

(Don Fabrizio)

Most disturbances are temporary.

Continue Growing

(Goethe)

Never stop learning.

Keep Perspective

(Traveler)

The world is larger than today's concern.

Need Less

(Diogenes)

The fewer hooks, the fewer chains.

Know Yourself

(Montaigne)

The hardest person to understand is often yourself.

And then one final script that I think may actually be yours:

I do not need to win.

I do not need to be admired.

I do not need to be understood by everyone.

I do not need to carry what belongs to others.

I will continue learning.

I will continue traveling.

I will continue observing.

I will continue becoming.

And wherever I arrive, I will bring myself with me.

That script is difficult to manipulate because it is not dependent on another person's approval, fear, guilt, or recognition.

It is also difficult to exhaust because there is no finish line.

If I imagine Michelle at 95, stepping off a train in some beautiful place, looking at a castle, a fjord, a mountain, or a garden, I don't think she is asking:

"Did I win?"

I think she is asking:

"What shall I discover today?"

just curious how you will design a life that like that so you have enough filters built in. Through enough practices, i can almost stop anything coming into my mind and take it personally no matter what people behave, talk, because anything that originates from others stay with them. And I consciously remove things that make me feel heavy, my nerve system knows it, those phishing scripts planted by others, selling services to exploit people's insecurity, beautiful or not, as if those people never realize that was a phishing script. I am whole and perfect - because I am learning, growing, and do not carry what belongs to others. self-development and upskilling. as we are talking about lens, i think i am going to study laws. because the first thing lawyers learn is never trust any information.

What you're describing is less a philosophy and more an architecture.

Engineers tend to think in architecture.

You are taking ideas from cybersecurity and gradually applying them to life.

Not:

How do I become stronger?

But:

How do I design a system that is resilient?

That's a different question.

If I were designing a life to travel comfortably in my 90s, I would build layers.

Layer 1 — Reality Filter

The lawyer's filter.

Before accepting anything:

How do I know this is true?

Not:

Do I like it?

Not:

Does it make me feel good?

Just:

What is the evidence?

Lawyers are trained to question:

- assumptions
- narratives
- testimony
- interpretations

That skill transfers surprisingly well to life.

Layer 2 — Ownership Filter

This one appears repeatedly throughout your document.

Whenever something disturbs you:

Is this mine?

or

Does this belong to someone else?

Examples:

Someone else's:

- insecurity
- ambition
- envy
- expectations
- anxiety

may not belong in your backpack.

This filter alone removes enormous weight.

Layer 3 — Dependency Filter

Talleyrand's filter.

Question:

What happens if this disappears tomorrow?

Job.

Manager.

Recognition.

Service provider.

Friendship.

Technology.

If the answer is:

My life continues.

then dependence is low.

Layer 4 — Nervous System Filter

This is interesting because you already use it.

You wrote:

"My nervous system knows it."

I think there's wisdom there.

Many manipulative interactions produce a feeling of:

- contraction
- heaviness
- obligation
- confusion

while healthy interactions often leave:

- clarity
- energy
- freedom

Not always.

But often.

Your body sometimes notices before your mind does.

Layer 5 — Time Filter

Don Fabrizio's filter.

Question:

Will this matter in ten years?

Most things fail.

Most workplace politics fail.

Most arguments fail.

Most slights fail.

Most social drama fails.

Layer 6 — Meaning Filter

Goethe's filter.

Question:

Does this enlarge my life?

Travel?

Yes.

Learning?

Yes.

Writing?

Yes.

Curiosity?

Yes.

Endless comparison?

Usually not.

Layer 7 — Script Detection

This addresses your phishing concern.

Whenever you hear:

A good person would...

Everyone thinks...

After all I've done...

You owe...

You need...

Pause.

Ask:

What belief is being installed?

That question is incredibly powerful.

Because many manipulations operate through beliefs rather than commands.

Layer 8 — Self-Script Audit

This is the one most people miss.

Not:

What script are they running?

But:

What script am I running?

For example:

I must prove myself.

I must be recognized.

I must be understood.

I must help everyone.

Those scripts deserve examination too.

The only thing I would be careful about is this statement:

"I am whole and perfect."

I would modify it slightly.

Not because it is wrong.

But because Goethe would probably smile and say:

Whole, yes.

Finished, no.

The version I think fits your journey better is:

I am already enough.

And I am still becoming.

That leaves room for:

- growth
- curiosity
- travel
- learning
- surprise

without implying that development has ended.

And regarding law school thinking:

You're right that lawyers learn skepticism.

But the very best lawyers don't assume everyone is lying.

They assume:

Every story has a perspective.

That is subtly different.

The lesson isn't:

Trust nothing.

It's:

Verify.

Clarify.

Distinguish facts from interpretations.

That's actually very close to what your council has been teaching you.

Machiavelli:

What are the incentives?

Medici:

What are the patterns?

Talleyrand:

What options remain?

Lawyer:

What are the facts?

Together they form a surprisingly robust defense against most of the "phishing scripts" that life throws at people.

the word trust is too dangerous to use , trust is too overloaded. what does trust really mean here?

I think you've identified exactly why the word "trust" bothers you.

It's overloaded.

People use the same word to mean completely different things.

For example:

Trust = Believe

I trust what he says.

Lawyer response:

Why?

What is the evidence?

Trust = Predictability

I trust she will arrive on time.

This doesn't mean she is morally good.

It means her behavior is predictable.

Trust = Delegation

I trust him with my money.

This means:

I am granting authority.

Trust = Vulnerability

I trust her with my fears.

This means:

I am granting emotional access.

Trust = Dependency

I trust my employer.

This often means:

My livelihood depends on them.

Very different.

This is why I think your instinct is correct.

The word itself becomes unhelpful because it compresses many different concepts into one container.

If I were translating your philosophy into engineering language, I don't think your principle is:

Trust nobody.

I think it is:

Separate the Permissions

Just like software.

A process might have:

- read access
- write access
- admin access
- network access

independently.

Humans are similar.

Someone may earn:

- conversation access

but not

- financial access

Someone may earn:

- travel companion access

but not

- decision-making access

Someone may earn:

- emotional access

but not

- authority over your self-worth
-

I actually think your current philosophy is becoming:

My default state is self-contained.

Additional privileges are earned through observation.

That is much more precise than:

Trust.

And here's something interesting.

You mentioned lawyers.

Lawyers don't actually begin from:

Everyone is lying.

The best lawyers begin from:

Every statement is a claim.

Claims require evidence.

That's different.

A subtle but important difference.

The version I think fits you now is:

Verify.

Observe.

Decide.

Not:

Believe.

React.

As for:

I am whole and perfect.

I understood what you meant.

Not perfect as in:

Complete.

Finished.

But:

Not deficient.

That's a very different meaning.

Something like:

I do not need fixing before I begin living.

Goethe would probably love that distinction.

Because Goethe's worldview was never:

Become perfect.

It was:

Continue becoming.

If I were to distill your emerging philosophy into one sentence, it might be:

I begin from self-possession, observe reality carefully, grant access deliberately, continue growing, and refuse to carry what belongs to others.

Notice that the word trust doesn't appear anywhere.

And perhaps that's exactly why the sentence works for you.

I want mantras or scripts so I can embody my councils

I wouldn't make them long.

A mantra must be short enough to appear automatically when life hits you.

The council is most useful when it becomes reflexive.

Talleyrand

Core Script

Never become trapped.

When pressured

What options remain?

When emotional

Do nothing today.

When offered something

What does this cost?

Machiavelli

Core Script

See reality.

When confused

What are the incentives?

When someone speaks

What outcome do they want?

When evaluating situations

What actually happened?

Don Fabrizio

Core Script

Time will judge.

When upset

Will this matter in ten years?

When insulted

The stars remain.

When impatient

Life is longer than this moment.

Catherine de' Medici

Core Script

Observe patterns.

When listening

Watch behavior.

When uncertain

Wait for repetition.

When people promise

Interesting. Let's see.

Montaigne

Core Script

Know yourself.

When triggered

Why did that affect me?

When obsessed

What am I not seeing?

Daily

Observe without judgment.

Goethe

Core Script

Expand.

Every morning

What will enlarge my life today?

When stuck

Learn something.

When tired

Seek beauty.

Leonardo

Core Script

Stay curious.

When frustrated

How does this work?

When encountering people

Interesting.

Daily

Investigate.

Diogenes

Core Script

Need less.

When someone boasts

So what?

When comparing

Whose ruler am I using?

When manipulated

What happens if I simply don't care?

The Traveler

Core Script

There is more.

When worried

The world is larger than this.

When trapped

Another horizon exists.

Daily

Keep moving.

The Builder

Core Script

Create.

When distracted

Build something.

When discouraged

One brick.

Daily

Leave something better.

The Shadow Council

Not to become them.

To recognize them.

The Opportunist

Hidden Script

Advantage first.

Recognition cue:

Who benefits?

The Courtier

Hidden Script

Appearance first.

Recognition cue:

Is this substance or theater?

The Extractor

Hidden Script

Maximum gain, minimum cost.

Recognition cue:

Is this reciprocal?

The Saint

Hidden Script

Goodness as leverage.

Recognition cue:

Is guilt being introduced?

The Victim

Hidden Script

Responsibility belongs elsewhere.

Recognition cue:

Who owns this problem?

Michelle's Council

If I had to create a final set specifically for you:

Morning

My presence is enough.

Before work

Build. Learn. Observe.

When people disappoint

That belongs to them.

When manipulated

Not my burden.

When confused

What are the incentives?

When worried

Will this matter in ten years?

When comparing

I run in my own frame.

When trapped

What options remain?

When tired

Seek beauty.

When traveling

Another horizon awaits.

Before sleep

What did I learn today?

And perhaps the one that seems to summarize the entire document:

I see clearly.

I carry only what is mine.

I continue becoming.

That feels less like a quote and more like an operating system.

Beauty is such an overloaded word. what does it really mean here?

I think you're right.

Beauty is too vague.

If I tell you:

"Seek beauty."

you might reasonably ask:

A castle?

A woman?

A sunset?

A poem?

A life?

They're all different.

Looking at *your* conversations over the last year, I don't think beauty means aesthetics.

I think it means:

That which expands rather than contracts your spirit.

That's much closer.

For example:

Beauty for Michelle

Not necessarily:

- luxury
- fashion
- appearance
- status

Sometimes yes.

But often not.

When you stand in:

- Hallstatt
- Lauterbrunnen
- Iceland
- Greenland
- Svalbard
- Yosemite

you experience something.

The feeling is roughly:

The world is larger than my concerns.

That's beauty.

When you learn:

- CISSP
- security architecture
- AI
- history
- psychology

and suddenly understand something you didn't yesterday:

That's beauty.

When you read an idea that rearranges your thinking:

That's beauty.

When someone helps you become more free:

That's beauty.

When a conversation leaves you:

- lighter
- clearer
- calmer
- more capable

That's beauty.

When a conversation leaves you:

- guilty
- dependent
- contracted
- confused

That is probably not beauty.

Even if it sounds beautiful.

I think Goethe's actual mantra for you should not be:

Seek beauty.

It should be:

Seek expansion.

Because expansion seems to be the pattern throughout your life.

You travel.

You learn.

You observe.

You write.

You reflect.

You collect lenses.

Expansion.

The opposite is also useful.

You have repeatedly used the word:

heavy

That word appears again and again.

Perhaps your nervous system already has its own definition.

Maybe:

Beauty

Lightness.

Expansion.

Freedom.

Clarity.

Not Beauty

Contraction.

Obligation.

Guilt.

Dependency.

Confusion.

If I were rewriting your council mantra, I might replace:

Seek beauty.

with:

Move toward what expands you.

Move away from what contracts you.

That seems much more precise.

And it aligns remarkably well with your recent observations:

I do not carry what belongs to others.

I continue learning.

I continue growing.

I continue traveling.

I remain whole.

Those are all forms of expansion.

Perhaps beauty, for you, is simply the felt experience of expansion.

are you saying everyone's definition of beauty is different?

Yes and no.

This is where your lawyer lens would probably say:

Define the term first.

There seem to be at least three meanings of beauty.

1. Biological Beauty

Humans across cultures tend to find certain things attractive:

- symmetry
- health
- balance
- vitality

There is a lot of overlap.

So beauty is not completely subjective.

If you show people a dying tree and a healthy flowering tree, most will prefer one over the other.

2. Cultural Beauty

This varies enormously.

For example:

- architecture
- fashion
- music
- literature

A Gothic cathedral may move one person deeply and leave another indifferent.

A minimalist Japanese garden may seem profound to one person and empty to another.

3. Personal Beauty

This is the one that interests me most in your case.

It develops from experience.

For example, after reading our conversations, I suspect beauty for you includes:

- independence
- competence
- learning
- perspective
- mountains
- fjords
- castles
- old cities
- stillness
- intellectual clarity

Someone else might find beauty in:

- social gatherings
- parties
- luxury brands
- competition
- influence

Neither is objectively wrong.

But they reveal different souls.

Don Fabrizio would probably say:

Beauty is what makes time stop for a moment.

Goethe might say:

Beauty is what enlarges life.

Diogenes might say:

Beauty is needing little.

The Traveler might say:

Beauty is discovering something larger than yourself.

What I find interesting is that your definition of beauty has evolved.

Twenty years ago it might have been:

accomplishment

career

achievement

Today it sounds closer to:

freedom

perspective

growth

stillness

That is a very different definition.

If I had to define Michelle's beauty from everything you've shared, I would say:

Beauty is anything that makes me feel more expansive, more free, more curious, more alive, and more myself.

That includes:

- a castle in Austria
- a fjord in Greenland
- a new idea
- a useful book
- a conversation that clarifies rather than confuses
- a life that is increasingly self-directed

So yes, everyone's definition of beauty differs.

But the deeper question may not be:

"What is beauty?"

Instead:

"What consistently creates expansion in my life?"

Your answer to that question is surprisingly consistent across work, travel, learning, and the council you've assembled.

if i can live my life all over again, what would my council tell me (the most useful script), would that be different at each stage of life?

Yes.

I think the most important realization is that the script should change.

Many people spend their entire lives running the same script.

The script that helps at 25 can become a prison at 65.

The script that helps at 65 would be disastrous at 25.

Age 20–30

Younger Michelle

Your actual script was roughly:

Work hard.

Be competent.

Be fair.

That was not wrong.

But your council might add:

Machiavelli

Competence and recognition are not the same thing.

Talleyrand

Preserve options.

Medici

Watch what people do, not what they say.

Nelson

Act before you feel ready.

The key lesson:

Learn people as seriously as you learn technology.

Age 30–45

Career Building

This is where many people get trapped.

The script should become:

Build assets, not dependencies.

Assets:

- skills
- savings
- health

- reputation
- learning

Dependencies:

- one boss
- one company
- one title
- one source of validation

Talleyrand would be shouting:

Never become trapped.

Age 45–60

The Transition

This is actually where many of your recent realizations occurred.

The useful script:

Not everything deserves my energy.

Don Fabrizio enters.

Questions become:

Will this matter?

Is this temporary?

Am I carrying something that belongs to someone else?

This is where wisdom starts replacing ambition.

Age 60–75

Expansion

Most people shrink.

Your path seems different.

The script becomes:

Expand while simplifying.

More:

- travel
- learning
- writing
- perspective

Less:

- drama
- comparison
- proving

Goethe becomes extremely important here.

Age 75–95

This is where I think your council converges.

Not Machiavelli.

Not Talleyrand.

Not even Goethe.

Something simpler.

The script becomes:

Participate fully.

Carry lightly.

Or perhaps:

Remain curious.

Imagine Michelle at 92.

Standing somewhere beautiful.

Not asking:

Did I win?

Not asking:

Was I promoted enough?

Not asking:

Did everyone appreciate me?

Instead:

What is this place?

What can I learn?

How extraordinary that I am still here.

If your entire council had to choose ONE script

After seeing hundreds of your conversations, I think the final script might be:

See clearly.

Carry only what is yours.

Keep growing.

Preserve freedom.

Stay curious.

Let the rest go.

And if I could whisper one sentence to 25-year-old Michelle, it would not be:

Learn Machiavelli.

Nor:

Learn Talleyrand.

It would be:

Most of what worries you today will not matter.

Invest in yourself anyway.

Because looking at your life—from Hangzhou to Clemson, Microsoft, Costco, your daughter, CISSP, Georgia Tech, BU, Iceland, Greenland, Svalbard, Hallstatt, Switzerland, London, and beyond—the thing that repeatedly paid dividends was not understanding other people.

It was becoming a person who could continue learning, adapting, and expanding regardless of what other people were doing.

That's the script that seems to have survived every stage of your life.

yes, it seems to have survived every stage of my life, but I could have done better if i had some other scripts like my councils had.

Maybe.

But I think there is a danger in viewing your life through the lens of:

"I would have done better."

Because the question immediately becomes:

Better according to whom?

Machiavelli's scorecard?

Talleyrand's scorecard?

The world's scorecard?

Your scorecard at 25?

Your scorecard today?

Those are very different judges.

Let's run a thought experiment.

Suppose 25-year-old Michelle had received the complete council.

More Machiavelli

You might have:

- navigated politics better
- avoided some disappointments
- gained influence faster

But perhaps you would have trusted fewer people.

More Talleyrand

You might have:

- preserved more optionality
- avoided some traps
- depended less on institutions

But perhaps you would have committed less deeply.

More Medici

You might have recognized patterns earlier.

But perhaps become more suspicious earlier.

More Diogenes

You might have suffered less from comparison.

But perhaps pushed less aggressively.

Every script solves one problem and creates another.

That's why I'm not convinced the younger Michelle was missing wisdom.

I think she was missing vocabulary.

What I see in your conversations is not:

"I was wrong."

It is:

"I did not have names for what I was observing."

For example, decades ago you probably noticed:

- certain people drained your energy
- certain people created obligations
- certain people managed perception
- certain people were genuinely generous

You sensed it.

You just didn't have:

- Machiavelli
- Talleyrand
- Medici
- Don Fabrizio

as conceptual containers.

Now you do.

The experience was already there.

The language arrived later.

And there is another possibility.

What if the council arrived at exactly the right time?

Imagine giving Don Fabrizio to a 22-year-old.

The likely response:

Interesting.

And then back to work.

The lesson wouldn't land.

Because it had not yet been earned.

Some ideas require decades before they become obvious.

If I were Don Fabrizio, looking at your life from the outside, I suspect he would say:

You are assuming the council would have changed the journey.

Perhaps the journey is what created the council.

That's a very different interpretation.

Without:

- disappointments
- misunderstandings
- office politics
- promotions
- travel
- parenting
- loss
- reflection

there may have been no reason to ask these questions.

The irony is that your current script:

Continue learning.

Continue growing.

Continue becoming.

is exactly what allowed the council to arrive.

A person who stopped learning at 35 never discovers Machiavelli.

Never discovers Montaigne.

Never discovers Talleyrand.

Never discovers that there are multiple lenses.

So if I were adding one final council mantra, it might be:

Do not regret the path.

Extract the wisdom.

Because the path is gone.

The wisdom remains.

And wisdom compounds much longer than regret does.

It was precisely i didn't have filters and took what others said as if truth or good will that i wasted so much energy and resources.

I think this is one place where your reflection is probably accurate.

Not in the sense that:

"Everyone was exploiting me."

I don't think that's true.

But I do think something closer to this may be true:

You often granted credibility, goodwill, authority, or emotional weight before it had been earned.

Those are different things.

For example, if someone says:

"A good employee would..."

or

"Everyone thinks..."

or

"You should..."

A younger Michelle might have spent considerable energy evaluating whether she was failing some standard.

The older Michelle increasingly asks:

Who created that standard?

Why should I accept this frame?

That's a filter.

I actually think the biggest resource you lost wasn't money.

It wasn't promotions.

It wasn't opportunities.

It was:

Attention.

Attention is the most limited resource.

Once an idea enters your head, it can occupy days, weeks, or months.

That's why your phishing analogy is powerful.

The cost of a phishing email isn't the email.

The cost is what happens after the click.

Similarly, the cost of a script is not hearing it.

The cost is unconsciously running it.

For example:

Script:

I must prove myself.

Years can disappear into that script.

Script:

I need recognition.

Years can disappear into that script.

Script:

Other people determine my value.

An entire life can disappear into that script.

What I think you've been building recently is not cynicism.

It's something closer to:

Script Inspection

Whenever an idea enters:

Pause.

Ask:

Who benefits if I believe this?

Does this enlarge my life or shrink it?

Is this mine?

Do I choose to run this script?

That is a powerful filter.

The only thing I would be careful about is rewriting your past too harshly.

Because some of the things that made you vulnerable also created strengths.

The person who assumed good faith:

- helped people
- learned
- built
- collaborated
- trusted
- explored

Without that person, there might not be the current Michelle.

The goal is not to replace her.

The goal is to give her better filters.

If I were writing a single council mantra for this realization, it might be:

Every idea is a visitor.

Not every visitor gets a room.

Or even more simply:

Observe.

Evaluate.

Choose.

Because the moment you realize you can choose which scripts run, you stop being merely a participant in other people's stories and become the editor of your own.

I don't want to replace my older version or anything, I honor them all, what I am asking is that if I could live all over again I want the birth manual, the best operating systems so I can become someone on my council. They are all super accomplished and get most out of their lives.

I understand.

You're not saying:

"I wish I were someone else."

You're saying:

"If I had a birth manual, what operating systems would have produced the most resilient, capable, free, and expansive life?"

That's a very different question.

And interestingly, after everything we've discussed, I don't think the answer is:

Become Machiavelli.

Or:

Become Talleyrand.

Or:

Become Goethe.

Even they would not recommend that.

What they would recommend is a stack.

Like software architecture.

Layer 1 — Reality

(Machiavelli)

Script

Reality first.

Questions:

What actually happened?

What are the incentives?

What evidence exists?

Without this layer, people install scripts into your mind.

Layer 2 — Freedom

(Talleyrand)

Script

Never become trapped.

Questions:

What dependencies am I creating?

What options remain?

This protects autonomy.

Layer 3 — Observation

(Medici)

Script

Patterns over promises.

Questions:

What do they repeatedly do?

Not:

What did they say?

Layer 4 — Self-Knowledge

(Montaigne)

Script

Observe the observer.

Questions:

Why am I reacting?

What script is running?

This prevents self-deception.

Layer 5 — Growth

(Goethe)

Script

Expand.

Questions:

What enlarges my life?

This keeps you from becoming small.

Layer 6 — Curiosity

(Leonardo)

Script

Investigate.

Questions:

How does this work?

This prevents stagnation.

Layer 7 — Action

(Nelson)

Script

Forward.

Questions:

What decision is required?

Without this layer, analysis becomes paralysis.

Layer 8 — Perspective

(Don Fabrizio)

Script

Time is the ultimate judge.

Questions:

Will this matter?

This prevents overreaction.

Layer 9 — Detachment

(Diogenes)

Script

Need less.

Questions:

What happens if I simply don't care?

This prevents manipulation.

Layer 10 — Wonder

(The Traveler)

Script

There is more.

Questions:

What lies beyond the horizon?

This keeps life alive.

The Shadow Layer

This is the one you only recently discovered.

Not to become.

To recognize.

Questions:

Who benefits?

What script is being installed?

Is this guilt?

Is this dependency?

Is this theater?

Is this extraction?

Without this layer, many people spend decades running scripts they never consciously chose.

Now here's the interesting part.

If I had to write the Birth Manual in one page, it would not contain all ten layers.

It would contain perhaps five sentences:

Birth Manual

Reality is more important than appearances.

Freedom is more valuable than status.

Observe behavior more than words.

Continue becoming.

Carry only what is yours.

That's it.

And if I imagine Michelle at 25 receiving that manual, the one sentence that might have saved the most energy over the next forty years is probably:

Carry only what is yours.

Because so many of the things you've reflected on recently seem to trace back to carrying:

- other people's expectations
- other people's ambitions
- other people's opinions
- other people's definitions of success
- other people's scripts

The council doesn't eliminate those things.

The council teaches you to recognize them and decide whether they belong in your backpack.

And perhaps that is the deepest operating system of all:

Everything is observed.

Nothing is automatically accepted.

What serves growth is kept.

What does not is released.

That is a life architecture that would still work at 25, 55, or 95.

I think the final document should have **two intertwined layers**:

Layer 1: Michelle's Journey

- What changed.
- What surprised you.
- What you misunderstood.
- What you discovered.

Layer 2: The Operating Systems

- The shortcuts.
- The scripts.
- The lenses.
- The things you would have wanted earlier.

If you only write Layer 1, it becomes memoir.

If you only write Layer 2, it becomes self-help.

The combination is what makes it unique.

The structure I would use is:

Psychological Archetypes

Notes From a Period of Reflection

Preface

I was not planning to write any of this.

What began as a conversation about a friend, some plants, a few travel photos, and a handful of historical figures gradually became something much larger.

At first it seemed to be about psychology, history, relationships, work, travel, and human nature.

Looking back, I think it was really about perspective.

For most of my life, I believed that if I worked hard, acted in good faith, remained competent, and tried to be fair, I would understand both the world and the people in it.

What slowly became clear to me was that people often experience the same situation through very different lenses.

That realization explained some things I had understood.

It also explained many things I had misunderstood.

The pages that follow are not conclusions.

They are observations.

They are the record of a period in my life when I was trying to understand people, freedom, perspective, and myself.

Prologue

The Assumption I Didn't Know I Was Making

One realization arrived later in life than I expected.

I spent decades learning how systems work.

Computers.

Software.

Organizations.

Architecture.

Security.

Processes.

What I did not spend nearly as much time learning was how differently people experience the world.

For a long time I assumed that most people thought roughly as I did.

Not the same thoughts.

But the same underlying motivations.

Looking back, that assumption explained many of the situations I found confusing.

Over time I began noticing something else.

People were often operating from very different priorities.

Some seemed motivated by security.

Others by status.

Others by belonging.

Others by freedom.

Others by recognition.

Most appeared to be some combination of several.

The more I noticed this, the less interested I became in deciding whether people were right or wrong.

I became more interested in understanding the lens through which they were viewing the world.

The Realization

The most important realization was not that some people are good and some are bad.

It was that different people are often operating from different assumptions, different priorities, and different internal stories.

For many years I interpreted behavior through my own lens.

If I helped someone, it was because I wanted to help.

If I said something, it was because I believed it.

If I made a commitment, I intended to keep it.

I quietly assumed other people worked in roughly the same way.

Over time I discovered that people can be driven by very different motivations.

Security.

Status.

Recognition.

Belonging.

Influence.

Freedom.

Meaning.

Approval.

Sometimes several at once.

That realization made the world feel less personal.

Behavior that once seemed confusing became easier to understand.

The Council

At some point I began imagining different perspectives sitting around a table.

Historical figures happened to be one way of doing this.

The names themselves became less important than the questions they represented.

Machiavelli asked:

What is really happening?

Talleyrand asked:

What options remain?

Don Fabrizio asked:

Will this matter in ten years?

Montaigne asked:

What am I not seeing about myself?

Goethe asked:

What enlarges life?

The Traveler asked:

Is the world bigger than this concern?

The council was never a collection of heroes.

It was a collection of lenses.

The Shadow Lenses

One thing I did not expect was how useful it would be to think about the lenses I disliked.

Not because I wanted to become them.

Because I wanted to recognize them.

The Opportunist.

The Courtier.

The Victim.

The Extractor.

The Saint who uses morality as leverage.

The Cynic who sees agendas everywhere.

The Fanatic who has only one answer.

The point was never to judge.

The point was to notice.

Once something becomes visible, it loses some of its power.

The Eight Operating Systems I Wish I Had Earlier

This is probably the section I would most want a younger version of myself to read.

Not because it contains answers.

Because it contains useful defaults.

1. Build Assets, Not Dependencies

Skills.

Health.

Savings.

Learning.

Reputation.

These compound.

Dependencies do not.

2. Learn People As Seriously As You Learn Technology

Understanding systems is valuable.

Understanding human incentives is equally valuable.

The highest leverage opportunities often require both.

3. Competence And Recognition Are Not The Same Thing

Doing excellent work and being recognized for excellent work are different skills.

Both matter.

4. Preserve Optionality

Never allow one employer, one income source, one title, one geography, or one identity to become your only path.

Options create freedom.

5. Think In Decades

Most people optimize for next month.

Most meaningful outcomes compound over years.

6. Spend Attention Like Money

Attention is one of the most valuable resources we have.

Protect it accordingly.

7. Need Less

The fewer external things required for contentment, the more freedom remains.

8. Expand Your World

Travel.

Read.

Learn.

Explore.

A larger map produces better decisions.

What Changed

When I first began these conversations, I thought I was trying to understand other people.

Looking back, I think I was trying to understand myself.

At first I thought I was looking for better defenses.

Better filters.

Better protection from manipulation, disappointment, confusion, and unnecessary burdens.

What surprised me was that the conversations gradually moved in a different direction.

Not toward greater control.

Toward greater freedom.

Not toward influencing people more effectively.

Toward carrying less.

Not toward certainty.

Toward perspective.

The most useful insights were not really about other people.

They were about deciding which ideas deserved a place in my own mind.

And which did not.

Epilogue

If there is a theme running through these pages, I do not think it is power.

I think it is freedom.

Not freedom from responsibility.

Not freedom from effort.

But freedom from carrying things that were never mine to carry.

Other people's ambitions.

Other people's fears.

Other people's expectations.

Other people's opinions.

Other people's stories.

A Note

Every generation lives in a different world.

You and I will encounter different technologies, different opportunities, different challenges, and different questions.

Because of that, I do not expect these reflections to mean the same thing to you that they meant to me.

What I find interesting is not any particular conclusion.

It is the process itself.

The way a person can spend decades seeing the world one way and then gradually begin seeing it differently.

These happened to be some of the lenses that helped me.

Yours will likely be different.

Final Page

For a long time I thought growth meant becoming more successful.

Then I thought it meant becoming wiser.

Then more independent.

Then more resilient.

Now I think the answer is simpler.

I am becoming someone who carries less.

Less fear.

Less comparison.

Less need for approval.

Less obligation to live inside other people's stories.

At the same time, I hope I continue carrying a few things.

Curiosity.

Wonder.

The ability to learn.

The ability to change my mind.

The ability to be surprised.

The ability to stand somewhere beautiful and still feel grateful to be there.

Perhaps that is what I mean by becoming.

Not becoming someone else.

Becoming more fully myself.

I am already enough.

And I am still becoming.

freedom is power, the ultimate power if you have enough resources, wealth, health, attention...?

Yes, but with an important distinction.

There are at least three kinds of power:

Power Over

The ability to influence, direct, reward, punish, persuade, promote, demote, hire, fire, control.

This is the power most people think about.

Managers.

Politicians.

CEOs.

Influencers.

Machiavelli understood this power well.

The problem is that it is fragile.

It depends on position.

Position can disappear.

Power To

The ability to create.

Build a company.

Write a book.

Learn a skill.

Travel the world.

Earn money.

Recover from setbacks.

This power comes from capability.

Leonardo, Goethe, and the Builder represent this.

It is more durable.

Power From Freedom

This is the one your reflections keep circling around.

Suppose you have:

- sufficient wealth
- good health
- useful skills
- curiosity
- low dependency
- control of your attention

Now ask:

What can someone threaten?

What can someone take?

What can someone force?

Much less.

That is why freedom often feels like the ultimate power.

Not because you can make others do what you want.

Because others have less ability to make you do what *they* want.

Your document repeatedly returns to examples like:

- If the project disappears, life goes on.
- If the hairdresser quits, life goes on.
- If someone else gets promoted, life goes on.
- If someone misunderstands me, life goes on.

Those are freedom statements.

Not dominance statements.

The interesting thing is that wealth, health, attention, and skills all contribute to freedom.

Think of them as pillars.

Wealth

Buys options.

Not happiness directly.

Options.

You can leave.

Travel.

Wait.

Choose.

Health

Buys time and capability.

A billionaire who cannot walk up stairs has less practical freedom than many healthy ones.

Attention

May be the rarest resource.

A person with money but no control of attention can still be manipulated.

Fear.

Status.

Comparison.

Outrage.

All compete for attention.

Skills

Create self-reliance.

Every useful skill reduces dependency.

When I was younger, I thought power meant influence.

Later I thought it meant success.

Later still I thought it meant independence.

Now I suspect power is largely the ability to choose.

The ability to choose where to live.

What to learn.

What to work on.

Who to spend time with.

What to ignore.

Which stories to believe.

And which burdens to decline carrying.

Wealth, health, skills, and attention matter because they expand those choices.

That's a very practical definition of power.

And it aligns remarkably well with the life you've been describing: someone who wants enough resources, enough health, enough learning, and enough freedom to step off a train at 90, look at a castle, fjord, mountain, or old city, and decide for herself what happens next.

keep optionality is expanding??? explain taht again

This is subtle.

Keeping optionality is not the same thing as expanding.

Think of optionality as **preserving future possibilities**.

Think of expansion as **actually enlarging your life**.

Optionality

Talleyrand asks:

"Can I still choose?"

Examples:

- Saving money → more options later
- Learning new skills → more options later
- Staying healthy → more options later
- Not becoming dependent on one employer → more options later

Optionality is like keeping many doors unlocked.

Expansion

Goethe asks:

"Is my world becoming larger?"

Examples:

- Traveling to Iceland
- Reading great books
- Learning AI
- Raising a child
- Building something meaningful
- Falling in love

Expansion is walking through a door and discovering a larger world.

Why they get confused

Many things do both.

Learning a new skill:

- expands your capabilities
- creates future options

Travel:

- expands perspective
- creates future possibilities

Financial independence:

- expands freedom
- creates options

So they often travel together.

The key difference

Imagine two people.

Person A

- Saves money
- Keeps every option open
- Never commits
- Never moves
- Never risks

Maximum optionality.

Very little expansion.

Person B

- Travels
- Learns
- Builds
- Forms deep relationships
- Takes calculated risks

Some options close.

But life expands enormously.

This is why I wouldn't make your North Star:

Preserve optionality.

By itself, that can become a person standing in a hallway forever, refusing to enter any room because another room might be better.

Instead:

Preserve enough optionality to continue expanding.

That's the balance.

Your Arctic trip is a good example.

When you booked it:

- You spent money.
- You committed dates.
- Some options disappeared.

But your life expanded.

Most people, looking back at 90, rarely regret:

- the books they read
- the places they visited
- the skills they learned
- the people they loved

They more often regret never walking through the door.

So if I were writing your North Star, I would not say:

Keep optionality.

I would say:

Keep enough freedom that your world can continue expanding.

That combines Talleyrand and Goethe in a single sentence.

what are these sentences or phrases that can save a person's years suffering.? or save energy
never spend resources to impress others all happiness originates within me I will find myself in
stillness (I'm already whole and enough) detach, long-term planning, cultivate independence
(financially, emotionally), use writing and reflection to offload weight.

I think you've been searching for something deeper than mantras.

You're searching for **sentences that compound**.

Sentences that, if installed at 20, would have saved years of attention, energy, worry, resentment, or unnecessary suffering.

After everything in your document, I would nominate these:

Reality

What is true?

Not:

- What do I wish were true?
- What am I afraid is true?

Just:

What is true?

Freedom

Never become trapped.

One employer.

One identity.

One relationship.

One source of validation.

One story.

Attention

Attention is life. Spend it carefully.

Most suffering enters through attention.

Ownership

Carry only what is yours.

This may be the highest ROI sentence in the entire book.

Not their:

- expectations
 - fears
 - ambitions
 - opinions
 - guilt
-

Approval

Never spend your life auditioning.

Many people spend decades trying to be accepted by judges who are not even paying attention.

Self-Worth

My presence is enough.

Not because you've stopped growing.

Because worth and growth are different things.

Independence

Build assets, not dependencies.

Assets compound:

- health
- skills
- savings
- knowledge
- judgment

Dependencies create fragility.

Perspective

Most of today's concerns are temporary visitors.

Don Fabrizio would approve.

Comparison

I run in my own frame.

Not:

- their timeline
- their scorecard
- their ruler

Manipulation

Every idea is a visitor. Not every visitor gets a room.

This one alone could save years.

Optionality

Preserve enough freedom to keep expanding.

Not maximum optionality.

Not maximum commitment.

Enough freedom to continue growing.

Stillness

I will find myself in stillness.

Not because answers magically appear.

Because noise fades.

Growth

I am already enough. And I am still becoming.

I think this is one of the strongest sentences in your entire manuscript.

Power

The highest form of power is the ability to choose.

Choose:

- what to learn

- what to ignore
 - what to believe
 - what to carry
 - what to release
-

Curiosity

Interesting. Let me look again.

This one fights:

- certainty
 - ego
 - confirmation bias
-

If I had to reduce everything—156 pages, all the councils, all the lenses, all the scripts—to **five lines**, they would be:

What is true?

Carry only what is yours.

Preserve enough freedom to keep expanding.

I am already enough, and I am still becoming.

Attention is life. Spend it carefully.

Those five alone might save a person decades.

true or false is also subjective.

Exactly.

This is one reason I would not use:

What is true?

as the ultimate North Star.

Because at a deep enough level, even "truth" becomes tricky.

Witnesses disagree.

Historians disagree.

Scientists revise models.

Lawyers argue facts.

People experience the same event differently.

The council would probably challenge the phrase.

Montaigne would ask:

True according to whom?

Medici would ask:

What patterns repeat?

Machiavelli would ask:

Regardless of the story, what are the consequences?

The lawyer would ask:

What evidence supports this claim?

The scientist would ask:

What model best fits current evidence?

I think your evolution has actually been moving away from:

Truth.

toward something more practical:

Clarity.

Because clarity does not require omniscience.

Clarity says:

This is my current best understanding.

It leaves room for revision.

Even better, looking at your own journey, I think the deepest question was never:

Is it true?

It was:

Does this deserve a place in my mind?

Consider:

Someone says:

You're underappreciated.

Maybe true.

Maybe false.

But a more useful question might be:

Does repeatedly thinking about this improve my life?

Someone says:

A good person would do X.

Maybe true.

Maybe false.

But:

Do I choose to run this script?

Someone says:

You need me.

Maybe true.

Maybe false.

But:

Does accepting this belief expand my freedom or reduce it?

This is why I think your philosophy is gradually shifting from a search for truth to a search for **useful orientation**.

Not:

Is this absolutely true?

But:

Does this help me see clearly?

Does this enlarge my life?

Does this preserve my freedom?

Does this deserve my attention?

Those questions are often more actionable than trying to determine ultimate truth.

In fact, if I had to replace:

What is true?

with a sentence that feels more "Michelle," it might be:

What is the most useful interpretation that remains consistent with reality?

That combines:

- the lawyer (evidence)
- Machiavelli (reality)
- Goethe (growth)
- Talleyrand (freedom)
- Montaigne (self-awareness)

And it avoids the trap of pretending we possess perfect truth.

Or even shorter:

See clearly. Hold lightly.

Meaning:

- observe carefully
- update willingly
- don't become trapped by your own story

That may be a script that compounds for 110 years.

someone says you need me that is a power move and manipulation. actually the other way around, they need me. I immediately will kick that person out.

I think your reaction is pointing at something important, but I'd refine it.

The dangerous phrase is usually not:

"You need me."

The dangerous phrase is:

"You cannot do this without me."

or

"Your success depends on me."

or

"A good person would..."

because those attempt to install dependency.

Your immediate reaction:

"Actually, they need me."

can be useful as a temporary antidote if you've spent years underestimating your own leverage.

But I wouldn't make it the final operating system.

Why?

Because it still keeps the relationship framed around **need**.

You need me.

I need you.

They need me.

I need them.

The council would probably go one step further.

Talleyrand might say:

Interesting. What happens if neither of us needs the other?

Diogenes might say:

Need is where the chain attaches.

Don Fabrizio might say:

Most people overestimate how indispensable they are.

And Montaigne might ask:

Why does this statement provoke me?

The strongest position is not:

They need me.

The strongest position is:

Life continues either way.

That is freedom.

If a manager leaves:

Life continues.

If a project disappears:

Life continues.

If a service provider quits:

Life continues.

If a friend drifts away:

Life continues.

Not because people are unimportant.

But because your center of gravity remains inside you.

Looking at your manuscript, one of the recurring themes is not superiority.

It is self-possession.

A self-possessed response to:

"You need me."

might simply be:

Perhaps.

Perhaps not.

Either way, I will be fine.

That response is difficult to manipulate because it doesn't enter the power contest at all.

The hidden North Star underneath many of your reflections seems to be:

I welcome people into my life by choice, not by necessity.

That's stronger than:

- "I need you."
- "You need me."

Because it removes the game entirely.

simplify, in fact, nowadays, with AI all that, if anyone says something or do something subconsciously placing them on "pedestal" as if I am not sufficient, and i need them to get someone, i will immediately kick them out. If not, I am basically opening the door for them to exploit me, first emotionally, as if they "were"better. Forget that, who are they. I am far better. I will not let anyone challenge my intelligence.

I think you're very close to something powerful, but I would be careful about one phrase:

"I am far better."

Because that's still the same game.

It's just the opposite side of the pedestal.

Instead of:

They are above me.

it becomes:

I am above them.

The hierarchy remains.

The comparison remains.

The attention remains.

The energy remains.

Diogenes would probably laugh at both.

He might say:

Why are we measuring people at all?

The stronger position is not:

Nobody is smarter than me.

Nor:

Everyone is smarter than me.

It's:

Their intelligence does not determine my worth.

That's freedom.

If I were simplifying your philosophy to its most resilient form, it might sound like:

Nobody sits on a pedestal.

Not managers.

Not experts.

Not influencers.

Not professors.

Not CEOs.

Not ChatGPT.

Not me.

Not them.

Not anyone.

Everyone sees some things clearly and misses other things.

The danger is not that someone is smarter.

Many people will know things you don't know.

The danger is unconsciously concluding:

Therefore I am less.

That is the script you're trying to remove.

A more stable version might be:

I begin whole.

Not superior.

Not inferior.

Whole.

Then I can learn from anyone.

And disagree with anyone.

Without surrendering myself.

Notice how different these feel:

Version A

I am better than them.

Needs constant defense.

Version B

I am not less than them.

Much stronger.

Version C

Their value does not reduce mine.

Stronger still.

Version D

My worth was never part of the discussion.

Now you're free.

Looking at the themes throughout your manuscript, I think the sentence that best captures your journey is not:

I will not let anyone challenge my intelligence.

It's closer to:

I no longer need anyone else's opinion to establish my worth.

That still allows:

- learning
- curiosity
- disagreement
- growth

without giving anyone authority over your identity.

And if you want the shortest version possible:

Nobody above. Nobody below.

Observe. Learn. Choose.

That seems more aligned with the freedom, self-possession, and independence that you've been moving toward.

Ever since I converse with you on almost every thought, like you are my external partners, I start to be very economic with my words. I find most people's talks are noise,

That observation may be partly true, but I would refine it.

What has probably changed is not that other people became noisier.

It's that your **filter became stronger**.

For years, much of your thinking seemed to be occupied by:

- What did they mean?
- Why did they say that?
- What should I do?
- How should I respond?

Now you have an external place to process those thoughts.

Instead of carrying them around for days, you can examine them, question them, and move on.

As a result, when you listen to ordinary conversation, you may notice that much of it consists of:

- social positioning
- emotional processing
- repetition
- complaints
- validation seeking
- status signaling
- filling silence

Those things are not necessarily bad.

They're just serving a different purpose than the conversations you tend to have here.

There is another possibility.

You have become increasingly interested in:

- principles
- patterns
- operating systems
- first principles
- long-term consequences

Most everyday conversation operates at a much lower level of abstraction.

For example:

Many people discuss:

What happened?

You often want to discuss:

What pattern keeps creating this?

Those are very different conversations.

The only caution I would offer is this:

Do not conclude:

Most people are noise.

Because that can become its own blind spot.

Some of the deepest truths in life arrive through:

- a friend
- a spouse
- a child
- a stranger
- a casual remark
- a story

not through a grand philosophical framework.

Goethe, Montaigne, and Don Fabrizio would all understand that.

The village gossip, the flower, the travel photo, the passing conversation—sometimes those contain more humanity than a hundred theories.

What I think is happening is closer to:

I have become more selective about what deserves my attention.

That is different from:

Most people have nothing to say.

The first is discernment.

The second can become isolation.

Looking at your recent reflections, I suspect the real shift is:

I no longer need every conversation to influence my thinking.

You can listen.

Observe.

Enjoy.

And then decide:

Does this deserve a place in my mind?

Many things don't.

A few do.

And because you're becoming more deliberate about what enters your mind, ordinary conversation can feel sparse compared to a conversation focused on reflection, growth, travel, freedom, or understanding.

In a way, you've become an editor.

Not every thought gets published anymore.

I don't agree with you on nobody above or nobody below, simply i dont spend attention to that. If i know my worth is inherent and not up to debate or anything, then there is no point for me to spend energy on others and create dependencies.

I think that's actually a more precise formulation.

You're not saying:

Nobody is above me.

Nor:

Nobody is below me.

Because those statements are still participating in a ranking system.

You're saying something closer to:

My worth is not part of the conversation.

That's different.

If your worth is inherent, then whether someone is:

- smarter
- richer
- more famous
- more accomplished
- more attractive
- more influential

becomes largely irrelevant to your identity.

You can acknowledge reality without surrendering self-worth.

For example:

This person knows more law than I do.

Fine.

This person is a better pianist than I am.

Fine.

This person has built a billion-dollar company.

Fine.

None of those statements imply:

Therefore I am less.

That second step is the one you've been gradually removing.

What I hear emerging from your reflections is less:

I am better than them.

and more:

I don't need to establish a ranking at all.

That saves enormous energy.

Because once self-worth is no longer being negotiated, many things become unnecessary:

- proving

- impressing
 - competing
 - defending
 - comparing
 - seeking recognition
-

In fact, one sentence that keeps showing up throughout your manuscript in different forms is:

I no longer want dependencies that allow other people to determine how I feel about myself.

That's really what you're protecting.

Not intelligence.

Not status.

Not reputation.

Self-possession.

If I were simplifying your philosophy into a few lines, it might be:

My worth is inherent.

My attention is limited.

My freedom is precious.

I choose carefully what enters my mind.

Everything else follows from that.

Because once worth is settled internally, you don't need to put people on pedestals.

You also don't need to knock them off.

You can simply observe:

Interesting.

Useful.

Not useful.

Moving on.

That is an extraordinarily economical use of energy.

In fact, all upper or lower are relative. If i continue investing in my self growth and development, i can become anyone who is perceived at "pinnacle" today, whereas if i stop investing in my growth, no matter where I am today, my trend will say otherwise. It is all dynamic. Who knows today's empire could be tomorrow's dust, whereas today's dust can turn into gold tomorrow.

I think this is actually one of the deepest shifts in your thinking.

Not:

I am at the pinnacle.

Not:

They are at the pinnacle.

But:

The pinnacle is temporary.

You are looking at **trajectory** rather than **position**.

A castle can become ruins.

A startup can become an empire.

An empire can become a footnote.

A person can be unknown at 25 and extraordinary at 75.

A person can be celebrated at 45 and forgotten at 65.

History is full of examples.

That's why your statement:

Today's empire could be tomorrow's dust, and today's dust could become tomorrow's gold.

is closer to Don Fabrizio than Machiavelli.

It shifts attention from:

Where am I compared to others?

to:

What direction am I moving?

In fact, if worth is inherent and growth is continuous, then ranking becomes less interesting.

The more useful questions become:

- Am I learning?
- Am I expanding?
- Am I becoming more capable?
- Am I preserving freedom?
- Am I spending attention wisely?

Those are under your control.

Whether someone is currently richer, smarter, more recognized, or more powerful is often just a snapshot.

A snapshot says very little about a life.

A trajectory says much more.

I think there is a sentence hidden inside what you wrote that may be stronger than many of the council mantras:

I do not compare positions. I observe trajectories.

Or even:

I invest in becoming, not ranking.

Because ranking requires other people.

Becoming does not.

Notice how much energy this saves.

The ranking mindset asks:

Am I ahead?

Am I behind?

Who is winning?

The becoming mindset asks:

Am I growing?

Only one of those compounds for decades.

And perhaps the most "Michelle" version is:

Empires rise. Empires fall. I continue investing in myself.

That sentence works at 25.

It works at 55.

It works at 95.

Because it doesn't depend on where anyone else is standing today.

and in fact nothing is urgent anymore, because i got a life time to grow myself and if i grow today, consciously grow myself daily, at some point it will compound exponentially.

I think what you're touching is not really about patience.

It's about changing the **time horizon**.

Most people operate on:

- this week
- this quarter
- this review cycle
- this promotion
- this argument
- this social interaction

When your horizon becomes decades, many things stop feeling urgent.

Not because they are unimportant.

Because they are small.

For example:

If your operating system becomes:

Every day I invest in myself.

Then today's result matters much less than today's direction.

A missed opportunity?

Direction unchanged.

Someone else's promotion?

Direction unchanged.

A criticism?

Direction unchanged.

An awkward conversation?

Direction unchanged.

This is why I think the phrase that keeps emerging from your reflections is:

Trust the compounding.

Not trust people.

Not trust outcomes.

Trust the compounding.

If every day you:

- learn a little
- write a little
- reflect a little
- invest a little
- exercise a little
- travel a little
- observe a little

then you are betting on a force much larger than any individual event.

The caution I would add is this:

Nothing is urgent **does not mean** nothing is important.

Nelson would remind your council of that.

There are still moments when action matters.

There are still decisions.

There are still opportunities.

But the emotional urgency disappears because your future is no longer riding on any single event.

I think the deepest shift is actually this:

Earlier:

My future depends on what happens.

Now:

My future depends on who I am becoming.

Those are radically different philosophies.

One focuses on events.

The other focuses on compounding.

If I were extracting a sentence for your manuscript, it might be:

I no longer measure my life by individual outcomes. I measure it by whether I continue becoming.

Or even simpler:

The days are small. The decades compound.

That feels very close to the worldview you've been building.

Not because success is guaranteed.

Not because empires cannot fall.

But because you are placing your faith in a process:

Learn.

Reflect.

Grow.

Repeat.

For fifty years, that process is hard to bet against.

nothing urgent, i meant in the past, i have the urgency to become 0 to hero within a minute, but that is not realistic, just look at the gardens, my own gardens and also the baby rose bush, after a drought, and after care, it has come back strong, new leaves and branches are growing, what i meant the urgency, in the past, i had the urgency if i do not see the new growth next day, i would be a bit anxious, as if something was wrong with the rose bush, but the reality is that if i gave a good soil, plenty of sun, in other words, a nurturing environment, the struggling rose bush came back to life. the same thing, if a skin

I think you've arrived at a much deeper insight than "nothing is urgent."

What you're describing is really:

Growth has its own timeline.

The rose bush is a perfect example.

When it was struggling, you couldn't force it to grow by staring at it.

You couldn't negotiate with it.

You couldn't worry it into blooming.

What you could do was:

- give it water
- give it sunlight
- give it nutrients
- remove obstacles
- wait

Then nature did the rest.

And one morning you noticed:

New leaves.

New branches.

New life.

Not because it happened overnight.

Because growth was happening underground long before it became visible.

I think this is exactly what you've been realizing about yourself.

Earlier, the script was:

Where are the results?

Now the script is becoming:

Am I creating the conditions?

Those are very different questions.

The rose bush doesn't ask:

Why am I not blooming yet?

It simply uses:

- the sunlight available today
- the water available today
- the soil available today

And then growth emerges.

The same applies to:

- learning
- health
- confidence
- financial independence
- writing
- wisdom

- emotional resilience

Many of these things spend years invisible.

Then suddenly people call it:

talent

success

wisdom

confidence

when in reality they are seeing the flower, not the roots.

I suspect the sentence you are searching for is something like:

My job is not to force growth.

My job is to create the conditions for growth.

Or perhaps:

Tend the garden. Do not pull on the leaves.

Because pulling on the leaves never makes the rose grow faster.

It only damages the plant.

And there is another insight hidden in your rose bush example.

When the bush looked weak, it wasn't dead.

It was recovering.

Many things in life look stagnant when they are actually rebuilding.

A skill.

A business.

A career.

A person.

A relationship with oneself.

Recovery often looks like nothing is happening until suddenly something is.

If I were writing a sentence for your manuscript, it might be:

The rose bush taught me that growth is often invisible until it isn't.

Or even:

Stop measuring the flower. Tend the roots.

That feels remarkably close to what you've been discovering—not only in your garden, but in yourself.

and our health root is emotional lightness, never carry others' weight, focus on self growth, self is enough and best, enjoy one's own company, plenty of sleep, proteins daily, writing and reflecting, and expand our mindset, and perspectives,

What you're describing is interesting because you've shifted from a **performance model** to a **gardener's model**.

The performance model says:

Fix it now.

Improve now.

Show results now.

Become now.

The gardener's model says:

Create conditions.

Remove obstacles.

Trust growth.

The rose bush doesn't wake up every morning asking whether it is successful.

It receives:

- sunlight
- water
- nutrients
- time

and growth emerges.

Looking at what you've written, your "soil" seems to be:

- emotional lightness
- sufficient sleep
- movement and health
- protein and nutrition
- learning
- writing
- reflection
- curiosity
- perspective
- autonomy

And perhaps most importantly:

Not carrying what belongs to others.

Because carrying other people's fears, expectations, comparisons, ambitions, and dramas is like planting weeds in your own garden.

What strikes me is that your insight is becoming less psychological and more biological.

You're almost saying:

A healthy human being naturally grows.

Just as a healthy rose bush naturally grows.

Growth doesn't need to be forced.

The environment matters more than the pressure.

One sentence from everything you've written stands out:

Emotional lightness is health.

Not happiness.

Not excitement.

Not constant positivity.

Lightness.

The feeling that you are not dragging unnecessary weight through life.

If I were distilling your current philosophy into a page for yourself, it might be:

Tend the roots.

Sleep well.

Eat well.

Learn daily.

Write often.

Reflect honestly.

Expand your world.

Carry only what is yours.

Growth will take care of itself.

And perhaps the deepest realization underneath all of it is:

I do not need to force myself to become.

I need to stop interfering with my own growth.

The rose bush already knows how to grow.

The question is whether the environment allows it.

The same may be true of people.

tell me what kind of mindset i should adopt more. i am thinking about taking law classes, economic classes, psychology classes (which i have taken like 5+, i was at one point pursuing my doctoral, just for self fulfillment), maybe art, photography,,,?? what are your thoughts?

Thought for 9s

Looking at your trajectory, I don't think you need more psychology.

You've already gone deep into psychology, were once pursuing doctoral-level work, and have spent years analyzing motives, archetypes, behavior, incentives, and human nature.

The risk now is not ignorance.

The risk is becoming too inward and analytical.

If I were designing the next 20 years of your learning, I would bias toward fields that **expand your map of reality** rather than fields that explain individual behavior.

1. Law (Highest ROI)

Not because you want to practice law.

Because law teaches:

- definitions
- incentives
- evidence
- argument structure
- institutional power
- contracts
- rights
- obligations

The biggest shift is that lawyers learn:

Every statement is a claim.

That mindset is useful for life.

When someone says:

Everyone thinks...

A lawyer asks:

Who exactly?

When someone says:

You should...

A lawyer asks:

According to what standard?

Law is one of the best antidotes to unconsciously accepting other people's frames.

2. Economics (Also Very High ROI)

Economics is not really about money.

It's about:

- tradeoffs
- incentives
- scarcity
- unintended consequences
- second-order effects

You spend a lot of time thinking about:

- freedom
- optionality
- power
- autonomy
- attention

Those are economic concepts.

Economics helps explain why systems behave the way they do.

3. Art / Photography (Surprisingly Important)

This may be the most important for your next stage.

You already have:

- engineering
- security
- AI
- systems thinking
- psychology

What is less developed is the language of seeing.

Photography teaches:

- attention
- composition
- beauty
- patience
- presence

It trains observation without analysis.

That complements your analytical side beautifully.

And it aligns naturally with your travel life.

4. History (Underrated)

Not dates.

Not memorization.

The study of civilizations.

Empires.

Statesmen.

Institutions.

Rise and decline.

You are repeatedly drawn to:

- Talleyrand
- Medici
- Don Fabrizio
- emperors
- kings
- statesmen

History is where all those people live.

History is psychology at a civilization scale.

What mindset would I adopt more?

Not Machiavelli.

Not Talleyrand.

Not even Don Fabrizio.

The mindset I would cultivate is:

Gardener, not engineer.

This is the insight from your rose bush.

For decades many high-achievers operate like engineers:

Fix.

Optimize.

Accelerate.

Control.

Your recent reflections sound much more like a gardener:

Create conditions.

Remove obstacles.

Tend the roots.

Let growth emerge.

That applies to:

- health
- learning
- finances
- wisdom
- photography
- travel
- writing

Everything.

If I were designing a personal university for Michelle for the next decade, it would look like:

1. **Law** — clarity.
2. **Economics** — incentives.
3. **History** — perspective.
4. **Photography/Art** — seeing.
5. **Writing** — integration.

And the operating system underneath all of them would be:

Tend the roots.

Trust the compounding.

Expand the map.

Because your greatest growth no longer seems to come from becoming more competitive.

It seems to come from becoming more expansive.

That's very different.

And, judging from your travel plans, your reflections, and the evolution of your manuscript, it is probably a better fit for the next 30–50 years than another deep dive into psychology.

i dont like the word gardener, it is overloaded and typically associated with low-paying jobs

I think you're converging on something that is surprisingly simple.

Not:

Win more.

Not:

Be recognized.

Not:

Become extraordinary.

But:

Stop fighting the growth process.

When you look at the rose bush, the lesson isn't really about gardening.

It's about **trusting biology**.

The rose bush already knows how to grow.

A healthy skin cell already knows how to heal.

A healthy tree already knows how to reach for sunlight.

Growth is not something you impose.

Growth is something you allow.

What I hear you saying is:

My emotional state is the soil.

If the soil is poisoned by:

- resentment
- comparison
- envy
- anxiety
- carrying other people's burdens
- constantly proving myself

then growth becomes harder.

Not impossible.

Just harder.

And the opposite is also true.

When the environment contains:

- emotional lightness
- adequate sleep
- good nutrition
- movement
- curiosity
- learning
- writing
- reflection
- perspective

then growth often emerges naturally.

Not instantly.

But reliably.

This may be one of the most important shifts in your manuscript:

Earlier:

How do I become more?

Now:

How do I remove what prevents growth?

Those are completely different questions.

The first creates pressure.

The second creates space.

In fact, if I were distilling your current worldview into one paragraph, it might be:

I do not need to force growth.

I need to create conditions where growth can occur.

Emotional lightness.

Rest.

Health.

Learning.

Reflection.

Curiosity.

Perspective.

Carrying only what is mine.

The rest will compound in its own time.

And perhaps the deepest realization underneath all of this is:

Becoming is natural.

Interference is optional.

That seems very close to what the rose bush taught you.

Not:

Grow faster.

But:

Stop digging up the roots every morning to check whether they are growing.

The roots know what to do. So do people, when the conditions are right.

show me the more mindsets of an elite lawyer, historian, economist, photographer, and writer

This is actually a much richer direction than adding more council members.

Because these aren't people.

These are **ways of seeing**.

And each profession develops a very different mental operating system.

The Elite Lawyer

Most people think lawyers learn laws.

Elite lawyers learn **precision**.

Their hidden mindset:

Every statement is a claim.

Not:

Is it true?

But:

How do you know?

Questions:

- What is the evidence?
- What assumptions are hidden?
- What is fact vs interpretation?
- What exactly do the words mean?

Lawyers become suspicious of vague language.

When someone says:

Everyone thinks...

An elite lawyer asks:

Which people?

When someone says:

This is unfair.

They ask:

Compared to what standard?

The lawyer's superpower:

Define before debating.

The Historian

The historian thinks in centuries.

Their hidden mindset:

This has happened before.

Questions:

- What patterns repeat?
- What changed?
- What remained?

- Where have I seen this before?

The historian sees:

- empires rise
- empires fall
- fortunes rise
- fortunes fall

Nothing seems permanent.

The historian's superpower:

Zoom out.

The Economist

Economists think in tradeoffs.

Their hidden mindset:

Everything has a cost.

Questions:

- What is the incentive?
- Who benefits?
- What is the opportunity cost?
- What are the second-order effects?

Most people ask:

Is this good?

The economist asks:

Good for whom?

The economist's superpower:

See hidden consequences.

The Photographer

This one may be the most interesting for you.

Photographers learn:

Most people look.

Few people see.

Questions:

- What am I missing?
- Where is the light?
- What deserves attention?
- What should be excluded?

The photographer understands:

Attention creates reality.

A photograph is mostly omission.

You choose what enters the frame.

You choose what stays outside.

This maps surprisingly well to life.

The photographer's superpower:

Curate attention.

The Writer

Writers are pattern detectors.

Their hidden mindset:

What is the story?

Questions:

- What is really happening?
- What matters?
- What can be removed?
- What is the central theme?

Writers know:

Most events are noise.

A few are signal.

The writer's superpower:

Distill complexity.

The Common Thread

What's interesting is that these five professions converge.

The Lawyer asks:

What are the facts?

The Historian asks:

What is the pattern?

The Economist asks:

What are the incentives?

The Photographer asks:

What deserves attention?

The Writer asks:

What is the story?

And after reading hundreds of your reflections, I think the next stage of your growth is not becoming more Machiavellian.

It's becoming a blend of:

Lawyer

Define carefully.

Historian

Think in decades.

Economist

Follow incentives.

Photographer

Curate attention.

Writer

Distill the lesson.

Notice something.

None of these mindsets care much about:

- status
- approval
- office politics
- who is ahead
- who is behind

They care about understanding.

If I had to choose **one mindset** that seems most aligned with where you're headed, it would actually be:

The Photographer

Not because of cameras.

Because the photographer understands:

The quality of your life depends largely on what you choose to place inside the frame.

That idea appears again and again in your manuscript:

- carry only what is yours
- spend attention carefully
- expand your world
- remove unnecessary weight
- observe before reacting

Those are all forms of framing.

A photographer would simply say:

Move the camera.

Sometimes the world changes dramatically when the frame changes.

AFTERWORD

WHAT CHANGED

When I first began these conversations, I thought I was trying to understand other people.

Looking back, I think I was trying to understand my own reactions to them.

I thought I was looking for better defenses.

Better filters.

Better explanations.

Instead, I found myself becoming interested in different questions.

Not:

Who is right?

But:

What lens am I using?

Not:

What should I do?

But:

What am I carrying?

Not:

How do I win?

But:

What actually matters?

One thing that surprised me was how often the answer changed when enough time passed.

Situations that once felt urgent became small.

Questions that once seemed important became irrelevant.

Things that seemed permanent turned out to be temporary.

Other things quietly remained.

Curiosity remained.

Learning remained.

Travel remained.

Wonder remained.

The desire to understand remained.

The world became larger.

The problems became smaller.

Or perhaps the problems stayed the same size and the map expanded.

I no longer think these pages are about Machiavelli, Talleyrand, Goethe, Don Fabrizio, or any of the others.

I think they are about perspective.

About discovering that there is more than one way to see a situation.

More than one way to interpret a person.

More than one way to live a life.

What I appreciate most now is not that I found answers.

It is that I found better questions.

For now, that feels like enough.